

1 Timothy: A Translation and Commentary

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Dedicated to Laurence Brown, a pastor to pastors, and to all

Preface

What follows is a fairly brief commentary on the book of 1 Timothy. The book is newly translated from the original Greek, with comments added after each section. Brackets in the translation indicate words *not* in the Greek, but added for clarity. Bolded words in the commentary indicate quotations from the passage being discussed. For the sake of brevity and focus, interaction with other secondary sources is minimal. Bibliographic information for the sources that are cited can be found at the end of this document.

Because the book of 1 Timothy principally concerns itself with various aspects of pastoral ministry, it is hoped that this commentary will be helpful to those in or considering that type of ministry. Prayerfully, others too will find their hearts encouraged and informed. If so, God gets all the glory.

Translation (1:1-2)

Paul, [an] apostle of Jesus Christ according to the command of God our savior and of the Lord Jesus Christ our hope, 2 to Timothy, [my] true child in [the] faith: Grace, mercy, [and] peace [be to you] from God our Father, and from Christ Jesus our Lord.

Comments (1:1-2)

In the Hellenistic tradition, letters typically began with the identity of the person sending the letter. Addresses were not used; letters reached their destinations through friends or acquaintances who by specific planning or fortuitous happenstance were traveling to or near the location of the intended recipient.

Given this interpersonal means of transmission, Paul could have simply used his name to identify himself, but he here (1 Tim 1:1-2) takes the opportunity to present himself in a certain light. Specifically, he points to his role as an apostle, a role carrying great authority (2 Cor 12:12, 13:10, etc.). He immediately locates the source of his apostleship in the sovereign directive of both God the Father and God the Son (**according to the command of God our savior, and of the Lord Jesus Christ**). By noting this divine origin of his apostleship, Paul might be aiming to reinforce for Timothy the authority inherent in the apostolic office. Alternatively, he might be aiming to underscore that whatever authority Paul has, he has only because God delegated it to him. The latter option seems more plausible than the former, since (as will be implied in v3) there is already a great deal of trust in the Paul-Timothy relationship. In any case, Paul is to be listened to, not for his

own sake, but because *God* has spoken.

Yet God is not simply a God who by dint of authority issues commands (**according to the command of God**), but a God who offers salvation and hope (**God our savior, and... Jesus Christ our hope** 1 Tim 1:1). God is no tyrant, content to take advantage of those with less power. He is a ruler who stoops down to deliver his people from the ravages of sin and holds up unending joy as the reward for those who trust in him. In light of a common misconception according to which God the Father is essentially wrathful and needs God the Son to placate him, it is important to observe here that the Father is himself a **savior**. The Father's wrath toward sinners is real, and so is his love for the world (Jn 3:16).

Just as Paul seizes (1 Tim 1:1) on the opportunity to present himself in a way that highlights God's sovereign grace, so he is eager (v2) to affirm Timothy: The Greek word translated **true** (γνησιος) connotes "affectionate appreciation" (Moulton and Milligan, *s.v.*); and by describing Timothy as his **child**, Paul points out the strong bond between them, for to Paul, the father-son relationship is one of profound security (c.f., e.g., Rom 8:15). Paul did not lead Timothy to faith in Christ (2 Tim 1:5, 3:15), and indeed, Timothy was already well-established in the Church by the time Paul met him (Ac 16:1-2). Even so, one never outgrows the benefits of personal investment from fellow believers (cf. Rom 1:11-12), and in some cases that investment can be so deep that the resulting relationship can accurately be compared to a parent-child relationship.

The manner in which Paul is Timothy's father (1 Tim 1:2) is not that of biology (physical fatherhood) or of legality (adoption), but of **faith**. There is an ambiguity here in the Greek (ἐν πίστει), in that the word can refer to the exercise of faith or to the body of truth connected with the Christian faith (the translation above puts the word "the" in brackets in order to indicate this ambiguity); Greek does not require a definite article for the latter sense to obtain, particularly since the noun in question is the object of a preposition. But the difference is immaterial: Faith is the introduction to and lifeblood of Christianity, and Christianity can, in a very real sense, be summed up with the words "the just will live by faith" (Rom 1:17).

Paul's usual greeting is "grace to you and peace." Whether this greeting is his own invention or something he adopted is uncertain, but it seems to be in part a play on words, since **grace** (χάρις) sounds quite similar (particularly in certain dialects) to what might have been the typical (certainly very common) greeting in Hellenistic times (χαίρειν); and in part a fusion of West and East, combining the Western-style greeting just described with a common Eastern greeting, **peace** (שלום; in Greek, εἰρήνη). In the present verse (1 Tim 1:2) and in 2 Tim 1:2 and Tit 1:4 (though not in this latter verse according to some manuscripts) he inserts between these two nouns a third, **mercy** (ἐλεος). The reason for the difference is evidently not that one greeting is for individuals, while another greeting is for groups, since the book of Philemon employs Paul's usual greeting. Rather, what is distinctive of the three letters that carry the "mercy"-type greeting is instead that they are addressed to men serving in pastoral roles. Perhaps Paul felt it advisable to stress to pastors—necessarily (1 Tim 3:6) men long acquainted with the faith—that God's *mercy*, not their achievements or station, was the thing to be kept uppermost in their minds. Or, if it is the case that these three letters were written late in Paul's life (the book of 2 Timothy certainly was; with respect to 1 Timothy and Titus certainty might not be possible), perhaps Paul's own heart had with long experience with and much meditation on the things of God absorbed its need for and the wonder of divine mercy to an even greater degree than it had in his earlier life. Either way, mercy, as well as grace and peace, is to lie close to the heart of the pastor.

These three qualities (**grace, mercy, [and] peace**, 1 Tim 1:2) are in Christianity not things that ultimately arise in and from humankind, but come from the Father and from the Son (**from God our Father, and from Christ Jesus our Lord**). It cannot be stated too many times that "salvation belongs to Yahweh" (Jon 2:9) or that "he is good" (Ps 106:1, etc.).

Translation (1:3-4)

[I write this letter] inasmuch as I made the urgent request of you to remain in Ephesus while I went to Macedonia in order that you might charge certain men not to teach differently [than the truth], 4 nor to pay attention to fables and interminable genealogies, which lead to controversies rather than the stewardship of God which consists in faith.

Comments (1:3-4)

Paul now begins to transition from the opening greeting to the body of the letter. By way of background for the instructions he is going to be giving, he reiterates (1 Tim 1:3) prior communication (whether written or verbal, we do not know) to the effect that Paul needs Timothy to spend time in Ephesus, since there false teaching had begun to find a home in certain influential men.

Paul does not spell out this false teaching in detail (perhaps Timothy was already familiar with it, or perhaps Paul felt confident that Timothy would perceive its nature soon enough). Paul does associate it with **fables** and **interminable genealogies** (v4). By Paul's day all manner of stories—some scintillating, most hagiographic—had begun to circulate concerning Abraham, Joseph, Moses, and other biblical and extra-biblical personalities. It might be these stories that Paul has in mind when he condemns **fables**, but in any case the mythological is out of place in Christian discourse (cf. 2 Pet 1:16). When he condemns **genealogies**, Paul does not intend to disparage Old Testament teaching in general (cf. Rom 15:4, 1 Cor 10:11; both these passages refer, as their contexts show, to the Old Testament) or Old Testament genealogical records in particular (cf. Rom 1:3, where Jesus' human lineage is singled out as central to his saving identity). It is not clear, however, what he *is* condemning. The translation “**interminable**” given above partly captures what might be an intentional ambiguity: The English word means “without end,” but can also convey an attitude of annoyance on the part of the speaker; similarly, the Greek word (ἀπεραντος) can mean either “limitless” or “ineffectual” (Montanari 234c). Whatever the content of the false teaching circulating in Ephesus in Paul's day, they were rabbit holes from which people emerged with nothing helpful gained, if they emerged at all. The same is true today.

Such things lead to **controversies** (1 Tim 1:4). Paul's own life amply demonstrates that he does not oppose standing up for the truth of God even when there is heated opposition (e.g., Ac 15:2). What Paul sets out to avoid is the antonym of **the stewardship of God which consists in faith**. (Granted, there is some uncertainty as to how to understand the Greek word here rendered “**stewardship**” [οἰκονομία]; another viable option is “arrangement.” Paul will in v5 go on to say that what he and Timothy seek from believers is the practical outworking of Christian teaching, so “stewardship” seems to fit Paul's train of thought better than “arrangement.”) Some debates disguise themselves as noble pursuits of truth, but the fact that they derail the normal outworking of a quiet faith in God shows that they actually are not noble.

In describing the true kind of Christian life (**the stewardship of God which consists in faith**), Paul notes that the driving force behind true Christian practice is not human effort, but **faith** in God.

In summary, there are false teachings which can divert Christians from their mission. Those who traffic in such false notions must be corrected.

Translations (1:5-7)

Indeed, the goal of our instruction is love [flowing] out of a pure heart, and a out of good conscience, and out of an unfeigned faith—6 some, missing these [qualities], turn aside to vain discussion, 7 wanting to be teachers of the Law, yet not knowing the things they say or knowing concerning what they speak confidently.

Comments (1:5-7)

Instead of the kind of controversy that stifles faith-sourced action (1 Tim 1:4), the goal of genuine Christian teaching is love (v5). Contrary to the opinion of many in the world today, true love cannot be detached from a pure heart or a good conscience. Consequently, one cannot approve sinful attitudes or actions under the pretense of love (for example, by condoning or engaging in homosexual activity). God is love (1 Jn 4:8), *and* he is holy (Rev 4:8).

Love is not something that the believer can conjure up within himself or herself by force of will: Faith is required (1 Tim 1:5; see also Heb 11:6). By qualifying the necessary faith as **unfeigned** (1 Tim 1:5), Paul does not aim to send anyone into paroxysms of cruel introspection or into fearful doubts concerning any and every act of faith one has ever exercised. After all, Paul, though well aware of the depths of his own sin (1 Tim 1:15), does not judge himself (1 Cor 4:3-4), for he has a clear conscience (2 Tim 1:3); and he, together with all Christians, possesses an appropriate kind of confidence in Christ (Eph 3:12). Nevertheless, there is a sort of person who projects an image of laudable spirituality and impressive faith, yet does so, not sincerely, but for the applause of

men, for financial gain, or some other impure purpose. True love does not flow from such people.

At least one alternative to love is **vain discussion**, i.e. fruitless argumentation (1 Tim 1:6). The misguided teachers at work in Ephesus evidently relish proclaiming themselves to be experts in the Law of Moses (v7). One of the ironies of this preoccupation, Paul notes, is that the teachers in question actually know little concerning the Law, or at least its true intent. Paul, being a recognized expert in the Law (Ac 22:3), is certainly in a position to recognize this deficiency on the teachers' part.

In speaking in this way about the Law, Paul opens himself up to the potential objection that he is speaking *against* the Law, which is, after all, a part of God's holy Word. To this potential objection Paul next turns his attention.

Translation (1:8-11)

Now, we know that the Law is good, if a person uses it lawfully, 9 knowing this: The Law does not pertain to the righteous, but to the lawless and the rebel, to the impious and the sinner, to the unholy and the profane, to killers of fathers and killers of mothers, those who murder people, 10 those who are sexually immoral, those who engage in homosexual acts, those who seize people to sell them into slavery, those who lie, those who commit perjury, and if there is anything else that stands opposed to sound teaching[, likewise with those activities], 11 according to the glorious gospel of the blessed God, with which I (of all people!) have been entrusted.

Comments (1:8-11)

Paul uses a series of word-plays in these verses (which wordsmithery finds a welcome modern echo in, for example, many African American churches), though not all of them carry into English. Especially notable is the first: If one sets out to use **the Law**, one should use it **lawfully** (1 Tim 1:8), that is, *correctly*.

Now, law codes are principally designed for the calling out of wrongful behavior, and of such wrongful behavior Paul gives a number of examples, while also leaving the door open to further types of sin (vv9-10). The identity of most of the sins that Paul instances are, I think, reasonably clear, with the primary exception of **those who seize people to sell them into slavery**. In order to clarify the nature of this sin, it should be noted that there are basically two types of slavery, viz. chattel slavery and *de facto* slavery. Chattel slavery is that form of slavery in which one person is nothing less than the personal property of another. This is altogether ruled out by the precepts and principles of the Old Testament (as well as the New). (Similarly abhorrent is race-based slavery, such as that formerly practiced in the United States. Such seems to have been unknown in ancient Israel and in the Roman world, and so is not directly addressed. Nevertheless, it stands altogether opposed to biblical principles.) *De facto* slavery is far more limited in scope, and while it certainly can be abused, it can also be an arrangement promoting meaningful work, rather than fruitless prison time, as a restorative for runaway debt. Yet even this type of slavery is discouraged in the Bible, and Paul in particular encourages people to leave the institution if possible (1 Cor 7:21). At the same time, Paul does not countenance revolution (Eph 6:5-8), though flight from a violent master would possibly be justified (cf. Eph 6:9, Mat 10:23). As mentioned, *de facto* slavery could in certain circumstances reasonably be entered into as a restorative measure. What is unconscionable, however—and what Paul condemns here—is the practice of using kidnapping or other forms of coercion to force people into slavery for personal profit.

At any rate, continually to delve into the Mosaic Law is continually to be confronted with one's own sin. If one has not murdered, one has, chances are, committed sexually inappropriate acts; and if one has not done that, one has, more than likely, lied; and if one has not lied, one has certainly done wrong in some other way. Furthermore, if one's attention is wholly wrapped up in these things, one is in reality wholly wrapped up in one's deserved condemnation, with nowhere to go for mercy. Being an expert in the Law—and only the Law—is like a doctor who is an expert at identifying different types of wounds but utterly incapable of applying a bandage. The gospel, by contrast, not only points out the problem (sin in mankind) but also the solution (grace in Christ). The Law is indeed **good** (1 Tim 1:8), but the gospel, in its all-embracing efficacy and salvific energy, is **glorious**, and in the light of it God is all the more seen to be **blessed**, that is, worthy of all blessing (1 Tim 1:11).

Paul is a preacher of this gospel. This role is a shock to him (the words “**of all people**” in the translation are an attempt to render εγω—a first person singular pronoun made emphatic because it is redundant after the first

person singular verb *ἐπιστευθην*), as he will go on to explain.

Translation (1:12-17)

And I am thankful for Christ Jesus our Lord who strengthened me, for he considered me trustworthy, placing me in ministry; 13 formerly I was a blasphemer, and a persecutor, and an arrogant man, yet I was shown mercy, because it was in ignorance that I acted [while] in unbelief, 14 and the grace of our Lord abounded, with faithfulness and with the love that is in Christ Jesus. 15 Faithful is the statement, and worthy of full acceptance: "Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners"—of whom I myself am first, 16 but for this reason I was shown mercy: [I was shown mercy] so that in me first Jesus Christ might display all patience, as a pattern for those who in the future will believe on him, [leading] to eternal life.

17 Now to the king of the ages, immortal, invisible, God only wise, be honor and glory for ever and ever. Amen.

Comments (1:12-17)

At this point Paul's immense gratitude to God the Son for saving him bubbles up. Paul takes nothing for granted. He brackets God's willingness to place him in a ministry role (**he considered me trustworthy**, 1:11b) by an implicit acknowledgment of his own weakness (**Christ Jesus our Lord who strengthened me**, v11a) and by an explicit statement that, in view of his own deep sinfulness, he was in need of remarkable grace (vv13-14). As to that deep sinfulness, Paul is unafraid to give examples: He reviled the name of Jesus (**a blasphemer**; so also Ac 26:9), attacked the Church (**a persecutor**; so also Ac 8:3), and aimed to impose his will on others (**an arrogant man**; cf. Ac 26:11 and, on the meaning of *ὁβριστης*, see Moulton and Milligan s.v.). It is true that these actions were not altogether boundless and capricious, for Paul, while still an unbeliever, was, like the Jewish people as a whole, seeking God's will zealously (cf. Rom 10:2). Inasmuch as his was not a high-handed, incorrigible sin, it is evident that Paul's heart was—though he did not know this until the blazing vision of the risen Christ on the Damascus Road (Ac 9:3ff)—in a state of preparedness for the reception of the gospel. Yet Paul's sins, though understandable, were just that—sins in need of abundant grace, along with the promise-keeping and self-sacrifice which God put on display at the cross (v14).

In fact, Paul's assessment is that he is the **first** of sinners. Ancient Greek does not have quotation marks, so what, if any, of v15 is a quotation is not wholly clear, but it seems reasonable to infer that the statement "**Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners**" is, or represents a portion of, an early saying or creed which—quite justifiably in Paul's view (**Faithful is the statement**)—was then in wide circulation among the churches. To this statement he appends the addendum that of these sinners, he is **first**. In saying this, Paul underscores the severity of his prior life of sin, magnifies the grace of God, and prepares the way for a play on words in v16: "First" of course easily speaks of highest degree, for Paul shudders with horror at what he has done against Christ and against Christ's people; but "first" also readily establishes something as having temporal priority and therefore also paradigmatic authority. In Paul's mind, his own undeserved transformation from sinner to saint sets a pattern for later sinners-cum-saints to follow. Certainly, Paul is not the first Christian, but he was among the first—if not *the* first—persecutor of the Christian faith to become a follower of Christian faith after the Resurrection. In this sense, many a converted anti-christian terrorist or combative atheist has Paul for his or her father. Paul also uses the word **patience** (1 Tim 1:16) to describe God's bearing with him until the time was right for his conversion (cf. Rom 2:4), and I have had the honor of meeting individuals who can reflect gratefully on God's patience with them as they remained in unbelief for many years, only later in life to accept the gospel.

This mediation on the gospel's outworking in his own life and in the lives of those who will follow after him leads Paul to launch into a doxology (1 Tim 1:17). God is **king of the ages**, which is close to saying "eternal king," but with an emphasis on the endless succession of variegated epochs over which his sovereignty extends; **immortal**, which places him beyond the reach of war, disease, or any such thing which frequently cuts short the lifespan and reduces the capacity of humans; **invisible**, which places him beyond the confines of place or of the physical phenomena over which alone the human eye has observational power; and **God only wise**, which ascribes uniquely to him full mastery over every subject and skill. In view of these traits, it is only right to ascribe to God eternal **honor**, by which the value of his authoritative station is rightly assessed; and endless

glory, by which the awe-inspiring grandeur of his splendorous transcendence is duly acknowledged. With his amen, Paul adds the weight of solemn affirmation to this word of praise.

Translation (1:18-20)

This instruction I entrust to you, [my] child Timothy, in accordance with the prophecies over you which go before you, so that in them you might fight the good fight, 19 keeping faith and a good conscience; some, repudiating [these things], have made shipwreck of their faith, 20 among whom are Hymenaeus and Alexander, whom I handed over to Satan, so that they may be taught not to speak so wrongly.

Comments (1:18-20)

After excurses clarifying the role of the Law in Christian teaching (1 Tim 1:8-11) and reflecting on the impact of the gospel in his own life (vv12-17), Paul begins here to segue to the body of the letter (which will begin in 2:1). **This instruction** (1:18) picks up on v5, and **I entrust to you, [my] child Timothy** reiterates vv3-4, with language similar to that in v2. Here he adds an encouraging reminder that the Holy Spirit had given notice ahead of time of a key role for Timothy. What precisely has been prophesied is not rehearsed. Whatever the content of the prophecies, the intended effect was not inaction, but a spur to action; for the Christian, predictions of favorable outcomes are not reason to sit back, but to press forward. Obviously the combat Paul has in mind (**fight the good fight**) is not literal, yet the struggle, though spiritual, will be fierce.

Even if the struggle will be fierce, it is not to be done in a no-holds-barred fashion. Instead, the combat against wrong views of Christian living is to be conducted with **faith** as a constant companion (1:19), that is, with an eye to the unseen things of God rather than the seen things of the world. This is already the fifth time that Paul has mentioned “faith” (πίστις), and that to a well-grounded pastor. Yet the constant reminders are salutary: In our own day, there is a constant pull towards immediate, tangible results and towards the methodologies of marketing experts. It must be borne in mind constantly that the Christian walks by faith, not by sight (2 Cor 5:7). The phrase **keeping faith** (ἐχὼν πίστιν) could also mean “exhibiting faithfulness.” The difference between these two approaches to the Greek is not a big one, since an eye toward heaven enables continued Christian work on the earth and precludes the use of worldly methods for this work; just possibly the ambiguity is intentional. A **clean conscience** is in any case critical, and also has been mentioned by Paul already (v5). To taint the good fight with embezzlement or immorality would bring about a moral **shipwreck**.

A shipwreck is precisely what some have made of their faith (v20). Paul gives two examples, Hymenaeus and Alexander. Since Paul does not provide descriptions of them or of their actions, it is safe to assume that Timothy was familiar with the situation(s) involved, though evidently some sort of sin of speech is the chief problem. (The translation “**speak so wrongly**” avoids the English word “blaspheme” for the sake of clarity: Though the English word “blaspheme” derives from the Greek verb Paul uses here, it is much more specific than the Greek βλασφημέω is.) It is also reasonable to infer that the prescriptions found in Mat 18:15-20 have already been followed, or to infer that the sins of these men are so public that the situation addressed in that passage does not apply. There is, however, at least one important point of contact between the truths found in Mat 18:15-20 and the principles underlying Paul's words in 1 Tim 1:20, viz. Jesus' “let him be to you like a gentile and a tax collector” and Paul's **whom I handed over to Satan** both point to a phase of church discipline in which the unrepentant offender is, in some sense, assigned a place *outside* the bounds of God's people, which of necessity is a place *inside* the bounds of Satan's cruel administration.

What precisely this discipline looks like—for instance, an institution which is supposed to turn to its enemy the other cheek (cf. Mat 5:39) is probably *not* supposed to refuse an unrepentant person entry into a church gathering—is not spelled out in detail in Scripture, and indeed, probably looks different from one culture to another, and perhaps even from one case to another. Nevertheless, there must be some real way in which the biblical doctrine of church discipline is put into practice as necessary.

Even so, Paul's goal here must be viewed as restorative. Paul's words **so that they may be taught not to speak so wrongly** could in themselves be construed as ironic and condemnatory (as if to say, “then they will realize to their chagrin that their wrongful speech has cast them forever from the grace of God”), but Paul's gracious and conciliatory posture elsewhere (e.g., looking just at the letters of Paul to Timothy, 1 Tim 3:3, 4:12,

5:1-2, 6:11, 2 Tim 2:24-25, 3:10, 4:16) all but demand that Paul's words be understood as expressing a sincere hope that Hymenaeus and Alexander, having for a time been reminded of the merciless savagery of life outside the flock of God, will (re)turn to the merciful tranquility of life within that fold. (Most likely, these men are referred to again in 2 Tim 2:17 and 4:14, respectively; but those sad events have not yet occurred as Paul writes the book of 1 Timothy, and they do not erase the generosity of Paul's disposition.)

Translation (2:1-2)

I exhort, then, in the first place, that pleas, prayers, petitions, [and] praises be made [to God] on behalf of all people 2—[including] on behalf of kings and all who stand in preeminence, in order that we may pursue a quiet and peaceful life in all piety and dignity.

Comments (2:1-2)

Paul's vision of "love [flowing] out of a pure heart, and out of a good conscience, and out of an unfeigned faith" (1 Tim 1:5) is not ethereal. It manifests itself in concrete ways—so much so, that Paul can list the action points he has in mind in a specific order, the **first** (2:1) of these being prayer. Someone once said, "A day without prayer is a boast against God." Said in hope of benefit, prayer is an act of love; said in expectation of results, it is an act of hope; said to the unseen God, it is an act of faith.

Not content with generalities, Paul gives four terms to designate different kinds of prayer. Paul does not say that *each* kind of prayer should be said on *every* occasion. It seems to me that he intends to capture the variegated nature of prayer. Each word is in the plural (though for the sake of definition, the following comments will use the singular), indicating that prayer is not to be a one-off event; it is an oft-repeated feature of the Christian life.

The first term he uses is "plea" (δεησις). The English here is intended to capture an ambiguity of the Greek, viz. it could mean either a cry of desperation, as when—to cite a modern situation—one's car "is slipping out of control on the icy road" (Brown, n.p.; cf. Moulton and Milligan, s.v.); or it could mean an appeal for a favorable intervention in the context of a courtroom appearance or a written appeal to a government agency. Since the latter meaning is strongly typical of the third term Paul uses—"petitions" (εντευξις, which will be discussed below)—the former is probably what he has on mind here. At times prayer is the shout of a person caught up in a sudden emergency.

The second term Paul used is "prayer" (προσευχη). This would seem to be the most all-embracing term for prayer, as suggested by the high frequency of the word (both in its noun and in its verb forms) in the NT; the difficulty entailed in pinning down its specific semantic content beyond "communication directed respectfully to God"; and the fact that when Paul later (v8), after a digression, resumes the thought of the present verse he uses this verb alone to do so. In this connection, it can be mentioned in passing that there is biblical precedent both for spontaneous and extemporaneous prayer (Neh 2:4) and for structured and preplanned prayer (Dan 6:10).

The third term, as mentioned already, is "petition" (εντευξις). This Greek word often refers to a more or less formal appeal to an authority figure. The Christian is one who can, and must, approach the throne of the king of the universe, confident in their approach due to the blood of Christ (Brown n.p., citing Heb 4:14-16).

The fourth term is "praise" (ευχαριστη). More literally, the Greek means "thanksgiving," but since in the context of prayer the English word "praise" frequently refers in Christian usage to giving honor to God for some particular benefit recently received, this English word, which maintains the alliteration of the previous three English nouns, seems justified. Moreover, in the Greek there seems to be a comparable play of words (notice the endings as construed in context, viz. -εις, -ας, -εις, ας), and the conspicuous lack of a conjunction. While beauty of expression is not to be an end in itself (1 Cor 2:4), it is fitting that in some measure words that bespeak God's truth should adorn themselves with God's beauty (cf. Ps 45:1, Ecc 12:10). At any rate, the Christian life is woefully incomplete without expressions of gratitude to God for all the good he has given.

Anyone and everyone qualifies to be the one on whose behalf these prayers are offered: Paul's **all people** (παντων ανθρωπων, 1 Tim 2:1) might be rendered "every single human being." Paul does not intend here to set up some impossible standard, some new arena in which the Christian can continually sense defeat and wallow in despair. He will later tell Timothy—who can hardly have prayed by name for every single human being—that he

(Timothy) had fully followed his (Paul's) example (2 Tim 3:10). Paul is saying that prayer should be infinitely generous and unreservedly kindhearted; to whatever extent one feasibly *can* pray for all people, one morally *ought to*. Prayer is not to be limited to oneself, to one's own local church, or to one's own ethnicity or preferred political party. Far from it: The imperative to pray extends to those in government and those of high station (**on behalf of kings and all who stand in preeminence**; 1 Tim 2:2). Though he does not say this, possibly the reason that Paul feels this specification necessary is the increasing degree to which the Roman imperial institution was in his day arrogating to itself honors reserved for God alone, persecuting Christians, and engaging in and encouraging all manner of debauched living and cruel treatment of others. Moreover, Christians in Paul's days largely hailed from the lower classes (1 Cor 1:26), while the upper classes specialized in exploitative practices (cf. Jm 2:6). Hence there might be a temptation *not* to pray for, or even to pray *against*, national leadership and the most privileged strata of society.

Paul urges believers to ask God to grant to leaders that discernment which will promote a society in which quiet godliness and cool-headed civility can be cultivated (**in order that we may pursue a quiet and peaceful life in all piety and dignity**; 1 Tim 2:2). It is a sign that Paul practices what he elsewhere preaches about having an almost unreasonable optimism and goodwill concerning other people (cf. 1 Cor 13:7) for him here to be able to visualize the Roman elite ruling well. Also, Paul is evidently disinclined to involve the Church in civil unrest (cf. Rom 13:1-7), though his own life provides ample witness to the need to proclaim the gospel in the face of any and all opposition (e.g., 1 Cor 16:9). In this regard Paul echoes the peace-loving sentiments found in the book of Psalms (e.g., 120:7, 122:6). For the Christian, the plowshare, not the sword, is the ideal tool (Isa 2:4; cf. Rom 12:18).

Indeed, while the coming of Jesus precipitates conflict (Mat 10:34), as does living for Jesus (2 Tim 3:12), Christians should not revel in foment and turmoil (1 Tim 2:2), but in **piety** (ευσεβεία) and **dignity** (σεμνότης). The first term refers primarily to reverence for God, and secondarily to respectful, appropriate actions toward other people. It is probably not necessary to choose between these two senses, since both fit the immediate and wider context well, and the ready juxtaposition of loving God and loving neighbors can only have been deeply imprinted on Paul's mind (Ac 20:24, 2 Tim 4:8; cf. Mat 22:36-39). The second term is more or less an antonym of "frivolousness." Christians, then, should treat God and others with the seriousness that each deserves. The Christian life is neither a superiority complex nor a wild party.

Translation (2:3-7)

For this is noble and acceptable before our savior, God, 4 who desires all people to be saved and to come to knowledge of the truth. 5 For God is one; one also is the mediator between God and humanity, the human Christ Jesus, 6 who gave himself as a ransom on behalf of all, a witness at the proper time, 7 of which I myself am a herald and an apostle. I speak the truth in Christ; I am not lying, [being indeed] a teacher of the nations in faith and truth.

Comments (2:3-7)

This (1 Tim 2:3) could refer to living "a quiet and peaceful life in all piety and dignity" (in v2a) to praying "on behalf of kings and all who stand in preeminence" (in v2b), or to the need for "pleas, prayers, petitions, [and] praises [to] be made [to God] on behalf of all people" (v1). The last option is most likely, since later in the present sentence (see v4) the words "all people" are repeated, thus connecting v1 to vv3-4. So the thought is that prayer devoid of ethnocentrism is something pleasing (**noble and acceptable**) to God (v3). It makes sense that God would desire this when it is remembered that God is **our savior** (v3); and that he desires the eternal benefit, not of a narrow slice of humanity, but of **all people** (v4).

This last-cited verse (v4), together with v6 (where Jesus is said to be **a ransom**, not for some, but for **all**), has prompted much discussion among theologians. The question is how it is that these verses can be true, when in other certain passages the goal of Christ's sacrifice seems not to have been *all* of humanity, but certain objects of grace from among it (e.g., Tit 2:14; cf. Hurrian *passim*). Some approaches to one or both of these two problems can be mentioned and briefly discussed in the following paragraphs.

(1) Some argue that God both desires and sooner or later accomplishes the salvation of every member of

the human race. This approach can be rejected decisively, for Paul himself denies that this is the case (Rom 9:22, 1 Thes 1:9, 3:2).

(2) Some think that what Paul means here is that “God wills (that is, decrees) to save (some of) all *categories* of men” (Reymond, 693); Reymond’s approach to v6 is essentially the same. This reading of Paul’s words, however much it obviates certain theological difficulties, seems to me tendentious, for to make the concept “some of” crucial to the argument when it is not present in the text—and what’s more, a seeming antonym (viz. **all**, *πας*) is present—is a dubious procedure. It is true that the crucial verbiage **all people** (*παντας ανθρωπους*) *might* mean something like “people of all kinds” (cf. von Siebenthal, §144b, p219; see further the following approach); but such would, it seems to me, hardly be equivalent to “all *categories* of people,” “category” again being crucial to Reymond’s argument.

(3) A variation on this approach is to suppose that **all people** means “all races of people,” more specifically “both Jews and Gentiles.” One weakness to this approach is it might read more into Paul’s words than he could possibly have meant. Another weakness to this approach is that the problem of clashes between Jewish and Gentile people has not been a central concern of the book of 1 Timothy so far. This latter objection is somewhat mollified by Paul’s recent criticism (1 Tim 1:7) of the misuse by some of the Law of Moses, given that questions concerning the present-day application of the Law of Moses tend to raise questions about the place of Gentiles in God’s plan; by the **God is one** language in v5, given that Paul elsewhere (Rom 3:29-30) argues from the oneness of God that God’s plan of salvation extends to both Jew *and* Gentile; by the fact that later in this epistle (4:3) Paul will push back against food prohibitions, suggesting strained Jewish-Gentile relations at Ephesus; and by the attention given to Jewish-Gentile relations in the epistle to the Ephesians (2:11ff).

(4) The verb **to be saved** (*σωθηναι*) in v4 is passive, and therefore could mean that what God wishes for is not that he himself would save all people, but that they would save themselves (cf. Ac 2:40, 1 Tim 4:16)—which, sad to say, not everybody does (cf. Hurriion 89-90). This approach at best solves only half the problem, since in v6 (“a ransom for all”) the problem will recur in a form that is not hereby solved; and it seems to me to read more into the verb than Paul is likely to have meant.

(5) A popular train of thought runs something like this: While God makes salvation available to all, the application of this salvation to any one person is contingent upon her or his decision to accept it. Therefore, God’s desire for mankind’s salvation is only partially met, since not everyone believes the gospel. As it relates to the present verse, considered only in its immediate context, this solution seems possible. But this approach assumes things about how God relates to the events of history and about the responsiveness of the human soul that are contrary to what is elsewhere taught in the Bible (e.g., Isa 45:5-7, Rom 1:21).

(6) With respect to v4, Paul’s language of God’s desiring the salvation of all can be understood as comparable to Ezekiel’s language of God’s desiring the death of no one (Eze 18:23, 33:11). But *not* finding enjoyment in the wicked person’s death is arguably much more passive than *desiring* the salvation of everyone; and of course v6 needs to be handled separately from this line of argument.

(7) Bavinck makes an argument that, it seems to me, might have appropriate application to v6: “Although vicarious atonement as the acquisition of salvation in its totality cannot... be expanded to include all persons individually, this is not to say that there is no significance for those who are lost. Between the church and the world there is, at this point, not just separation and contrast. It is not the case that Christ has acquired everything for the former and nothing for the latter,” (3:470) for “when Christ was made to be sin and bore the sin of the world, he also nullified sin with all its consequences. The liberation of the created world from the bondage of decay, the glorification of creation, the renewal of heaven and earth—all this is the fruit of the cross of Christ (Rom 8:19ff.)” (3:471). The broad scope of the effects of the cross cannot be denied (Eph 1:10, Col 1:20; so Bavinck 3:472). In this connection it is to be noted that the Greek word behind **on behalf of** in v6 (*υπερ*), can, even in salvific contexts, bear a fairly general sense of “to the benefit of” instead of the more narrow sense “in the place of” (cf. Harris 213, citing and discussing 2 Cor 5:14-15; Harris himself describes the present passage in terms of substitution on page 215). It must be admitted that if this is what Paul’s words here mean, there is nothing in these verses that *demand* they be taken this way, rather than in the sense of obtaining the salvation of the elect.

(8) An all-inclusive statement can, it seems, at times be an exaggeration—not by way of deception, or on

account of an inflated sense of self-importance, but as an indication of heightened emotions or an effusive mood on the part of the speaker. Examples include Eph 6:21 (“everything”) and Col 1:28 (“every person”). Certainly Paul is effusive in what he has written in so far in the book of 1 Timothy: As noted above, in 1:20 he can and does picture restoration for his opponents; in 2:1, “all” can hardly be literal in practice, but in theory and in spirit it is; and in 2:2 he surprisingly calls for prayer for the Roman government itself. It seems possible, then, that here Paul does not mean to be understood as saying that literally every person will be saved. The approach outlined in this last paragraph is the one I tentatively favor. (Options 3 and 7 are to my mind the most viable alternatives.) In any case, Paul does not feel it necessary in this passage to answer every question theologians have about these things.

Returning to 1 Tim 2:4, Paul adds the words **and come to the knowledge of the truth**. Possibly this is to clarify that the salvation just mentioned is from sin: The Greek (σωζω) is a bit more ambiguous than the English in that it could refer to rescue from something other than sin and its results. But it must be said that within the thoroughly theological context of 1 Timothy, the spiritual meaning is probably what would have first come to mind. Another possible reason for the inclusion of this wording is again to tie the Christian life to proper teaching (cf. 1:3-11). These options are not mutually exclusive. Paul uses very similar verbiage elsewhere (Col 2:2, 3:10, 1 Tim 2:25, 3:7; cf. Rom 2:4, 2 Cor 7:9).

Whatever the exact meaning of v4 as a whole, Paul in v5 ties the truths just stated to the oneness of God (**God is one**). “The Lord our God, the Lord is one” (Deut 6:4) is a foundational statement in the NT (e.g., Mk 12:29, Eph 4:6, Jm 2:19), as well as in ancient, medieval, and modern Judaism. There has been much debate about the exact meaning of the Hebrew there (יהוה אלהינו יהוה אחד), principally whether it means something more than simply that there is only one God. Probably it does, but it does not mean *less* than that. Judaism, and its heir and fulfillment Christianity, has, whenever it has been true to itself, stood athwart the efforts of people all around it to multiply deities. In so doing, Judeo-Christianity creates a truer basis for multiculturalism than alternatives to monotheism do. For whereas the nations that do not know God split people into an endless array of tribes with different trusted voices and varying moral standards, those who recognize one and only one God place *all* people under his gaze; and if all are under his gaze, all are within reach of one another. Mankind consigns itself to an archipelago, whereas God offers it a continent. Since their God is God of all, Christians can pray for all.

Pressing further into God's all-encompassing reign, Paul adds to the statement **God is one** the proposition **one also is the mediator between God and humanity, the human Christ Jesus** (1 Tim 2:5). To the first statement Judaism wholeheartedly assents; the second marks off Christianity as neither an alter-ego of Judaism (or, for that matter, Islam) nor, in the final analysis, a sect of Judaism. Judaism is the seed; Christianity is the tree. The catalyst for this transformation (or really, actualization) is, of course, Christ himself. Paul at once puts Jesus on the same level as God, saying that God is **one** and that Jesus is **one** in the same breath. But Jesus is not some new label for God, some new perspective on him; he is a person distinct from—though equal to—the Father. Further, in adding to his divine nature a human one (**the human**), Jesus constitutes the bridge (**mediator**) between the holy and the unholy (**between God and humanity**). Jesus is probably referred to here as **Christ Jesus** to give special attention to his messianic office, **Christ** (Χριστός) being the Greek equivalent of the Hebrew “messiah” (משיח). Since Jesus is **one**, there is one path of salvation for all humanity. This singularity is a source of great reassurance, for the tribes into which humanity continually divides itself have no need to seek out individualized methods of salvation; all look for deliverance to one and the same representative of all mankind, Jesus Christ.

This deliverance is available because of Jesus' self-sacrifice (v6). The term **ransom** (αντιλυτρον) bespeaks an exchange, viz. the exchange on the cross of Jesus' righteousness for the guilt of those who will believe on him. When Paul describes Jesus' giving of himself as a **witness** (μαρτυριον), he probably means something very similar to what he says in Rom 3:21ff (“But now the righteousness of God has been manifested [φανερωσ]... [in Jesus]”); the cross was God's announcement to the world that on his Son hangs the fate of every human. The timing of Jesus' death was carefully and perfectly planned (**at the proper time**). (The plural of καιρος seems to have been interchangeable with the singular: Cf. Moulton-Milligan *s.v.* and observe similar usages of the plural by Paul in 1 Tim 6:15 and Tit 1:3.) All of history had been orchestrated to lead the moment when God became human (so also Gal 4:3). To use an analogy from chess, God had up until that point been

carefully maneuvering pieces on the board; then at the key moment he surprised everyone by sacrificing his most powerful piece in order to bring about success.

In 1 Tim 2:7 Paul reiterates what he has already indicated in 1:1 and 1:12-17, viz. that it is his life's work to proclaim this message of salvation in Christ to all humanity (**a teacher of the nations**). The emphatic manner in which he ties himself in (**I myself**) perhaps reflects his amazement at God's grace to him (cf. 1:12ff).

Paul's insistence that he is telling the truth (**I speak the truth in Christ; I am not lying**) is surely not an indication that he suspects Timothy will not believe him, since he trusted Timothy sufficiently to represent him at Ephesus (1:3). Similar statements of Paul's appear a number of times elsewhere (e.g., Rom 9:1, 2 Cor 10:31, Gal 1:20, Phil 1:8) in a variety of circumstances. My best guess is that these sorts of statements are for Paul the sort of marker of emphasis that in Jesus' discourse appear as "truly" (αμην) or "truly, truly" (αμην αμην). Everyone has his or her favorite turns of phrase, and Paul is no exception. What Paul is underscoring, then, is not the credibility of his statement that he is a **teacher** of the nations but his deep emotion.

Paul seemingly cannot go long without mentioning **faith** (1 Tim 2:7), and he does so again with reference to his international teaching. He also indicates that biblical faith is not, contrary to a common misconception of our own day, a leap in the dark. Rather, it has its basis in and true companionship with **truth** (cf. 2 Pet 1:16).

Translation (2:8)

I direct, then, the men in every place to pray, lifting up pious hands without anger or argument.

Comments (2:8)

After pausing to dwell on God's boundary-jumping grace (1 Tim 2:3-7), Paul returns to the main thought begun in v1. Prayer is imperative, and Paul has more to say about how it ought to be done.

The term translated **the men** here (τους ανδρους) does indeed ordinarily refer to males, and that the precept *is* gender-specific is confirmed when in v9 Paul will expressly turn his attention to the females in the church (ωσαντως και τας γυναικας), implying that he had recently been speaking to the males in the church. Of course, Paul does not mean to say that women should not pray (5:5), only that men should be known for devotion to prayer. Men in a very general sense are, or ought to be, leaders; and leaders ought to model honorable behavior. As far as Paul is concerned, the place for men to start modeling honorable behavior is by being an example of prayer.

When Paul says **in every place** (εν παντι τοπω), this might simply be a way of saying "everywhere" (as in 2 Cor 2:14). But in 1 Cor 1:2 this phrase is parallel to "the church of God which is in Corinth," suggesting that the phrase might mean "in every church." Reading the phrase in this way would jive well with the ecclesiastical concern of this letter as a whole. In the present case, **in every place** serves not so much to broaden the geographic scope of the command, but to connect the life of the Ephesian church with that of the global Church (cf. 1 Cor 11:16 for a similar appeal to pan-ecclesiastical practice).

Raising the hand can signify the catching of someone's attention (Isa 49:22), the making of a solemn promise (Rev 10:5), or the pronouncement of blessing upon God (Ps 63:4) or upon man (Lk 24:50). Surely God hears a man's prayer whether his hands are raised or not, but at least as a norm there is much to commend raising them. Yet these hands lifted in prayer must be pure (so also Isa 1:15), for no merely external display will satisfy a holy God.

Indeed, the very attitude brought to prayer matters. Both **anger** and **argument** are problematic items that occupy Paul's attention elsewhere as well (e.g., Eph 4:26 and Phil 2:14). The former is not wrong in itself, but when prolonged plays into the devil's hands. The latter is altogether out of place, whether directed against God (Rom 1:21) or against man (Rom 14:1); nothing is gained when one considers one's mental acuity to be a cut above that of another person. The slogan "prayer changes things" is true in a certain sense. It is *not* true, however, in the sense that prayer has any intrinsic power. For it is God who acts through prayer, and he will not tolerate hardheartedness or hubris (cf. Ps 66:18), no matter how impressive the prayer (Mat 6:5).

Nowadays, men with deep commitments to the spiritual things, let alone to prayer, are rare indeed. Perhaps this is not a new phenomenon. For instance, when Paul searched for a place of prayer by the river in

Philippi, he found women (Ac 16:13). Women today, like those at Philippi, or like Anna in the Temple (Lk 2:36-27), or like countless others down through history, ought to be encouraged to continue in their prayer lives. At the same time, perhaps it is not absurd if, among other things, they pray for there to be men who will pray also; indeed, for there to be men in the Church who are not known as men of power, but as men of prayer. Whether or not many men show themselves to be men in this respect, we have the promise of Christ that he will build his church (Mat 16:18).

Translation (2:9-10)

*Similarly, the women [I] also [have instructions for: Namely, I say that they] should clothe themselves in decent attire, with modesty and thoughtfulness; [moreover, they should] not [adorn themselves] with braids, gold, pearls, or ostentatious clothing, **10** but rather, as is proper for women who have devoted themselves to the fear of God, with good works.*

Comments (2:9-10)

Paul's style, as is sometimes noted by commentators, is not always overly tidy, which in part explains the need for many bracketed words here; also, the words in 1 Tim 2:9 here translated **similarly** (ὡσαύτως) and **also** (καί) seem at times to be used in a fairly loose connective sense. At any rate, just as Paul has addressed the men of the church specifically (2:1-2, v8), now (vv9-10) he gives instruction for the women.

Religiously-minded people down through the ages, not least real or professing Christians, have often specialized in prudery. In this connection it is worth noting that the attire of women was no obsession of Paul's, for in his thirteen epistles in the NT, he discusses the matter only here and, in response to a rather different situation, in 1 Cor 11:2-16. Also, Paul is by no means instituting a dress code. Indeed, given his consistent opposition to any misguided reintroduction of the Law (or the introduction of anything similar), he surely would have opposed the imposition of a uniform (such as those required by some Christian, Muslim, and other communities today). As to why Paul *does* take the trouble to address the topic of modesty here, we can only speculate. Possibly Ephesus was particularly prone to immodesty.

In any case, Paul addresses the problem of sexually provocative clothing in the first half of 1 Tim 2:9. It is true that a man's lust is his own sin, originating in his own heart (cf. Mat 5:28, 15:19). Yet it is also true that a Christian must be careful to avoid setting a trap that could ensnare another Christian in sin (cf. Mat 18:7, Rev 2:14). Hence Paul calls for clothing (the exact meaning of καταστολή is disputed by scholars, but not in a way that makes much difference to the overall thrust of the passage) that is reflective of **modesty** (αἰδώς) and **thoughtfulness** (σωφροσύνη). The former word speaks of choosing not to flaunt one's beauty; the latter term signifies thoughtful, measured conduct, often with particular reference to avoiding sexual provocation (cf. Montanari 2078b-c). How these goals are accomplished will vary widely from culture to culture and era to era. But the fact that the line between appropriate and inappropriate attire can be difficult to draw does not mean that a line does not exist.

The second half of 1 Tim 2:9, Paul pivots from sexually provocative clothing to socially provocative clothing. Wearing overly expensive and/or time-consuming styles tends to signal that one is, or aims to be, high on the social pecking order. This inflates the ego, provokes competition, and diverts attention from more important things, namely **good works** (v10). Comparison with other passages of Scripture (e.g., SS 4:9) indicates that jewelry is not inherently and at all times wrong. But if a woman is more concerned with her appearance than she is with her actions, she is distorting the gospel. The glorious Son of God was hung, beaten and disgraced, on a cross in a supreme act of good; it is only fitting **for women who have devoted themselves to the fear of God** (on επαγγέλλομαι in this context, cf. Moulton and Milligan s.v.) to honor this paradigm with merciful aid to others, not self-centered display.

In some cases in church history, women have set up various institutions dedicated to certain good works that operate quite separately from the larger church and its leadership. This is probably better than doing nothing, but given the centrality of the Church in God's program (Eph 3:21, 1 Tim 3:15, etc.), it is surely preferable in some way to integrate any such efforts with the life of the local church as a whole. Whether there is any formal program or not, good works ought to be what characterizes the women of the church.

Translation (2:11-15)

A woman must quietly listen to teaching with entire submissiveness, 12 and I do not permit a woman to teach, nor to hold mastery over a man, but to be quiet. 13 For Adam was fashioned first, then Eve; 14 and Adam was not deceived, but the woman, being deceived, came to be [involved] in transgression, 15 but will be saved through childbirth, if she remains in faith, love, and holiness, with self-control.

Comments (2:11-15)

Having given instructions to women (1 Tim 2:9-10) which complement those given to men (2:1-2, v8), Paul feels it necessary to provide a brief excursus on the question of women and leadership. Depending on how one counts it, Paul discusses gender roles in half or more of his epistles. Peter, who apparently wrote only two epistles, discusses it in the first of them. Perhaps gender relations were controversial among Christians in the first century, or perhaps they were considered by the apostles to be highly important.

In modern times the subject is undeniably controversial, at least in the global West; and it is also certainly important, though the gospel is not at stake. There are sincere Christians on both sides of the debate, and there is a vast literature on this subject. Since one of the goals of this commentary is brevity, I will, for better or worse, give only my own reasoned opinion. As with everything, Christians should examine the Scriptures for themselves (Ac 17:11).

The word **quietly** (ἡσυχία) in 1 Tim 2:11 probably does not indicate volume level as such (Paul, after all, in 1 Cor 11:5 permits women to prophesy in church), but an attitude that is non-combative. So, for instance, calls of female church members during the church service are not out of place where these calls are indications of affirmation, agreement, and attention. What would be out of place would be public disagreement or voiced disrespect.

When Paul says **entire submissiveness** (ἐν πασῇ υποταγῇ), he is clearly restricting his comments to situations in which the teaching is not sinful (cf. Ac 5:29). That he takes this for granted here is consistent with his generous tone in this epistle, and displays an admirable optimism from a man who was all too aware of the dangers one can face even—in some ways especially—in the church (2 Cor 11:26), including *this* church (Ac 20:29). At other points in some of his other letters Paul talks about how he can be so optimistic (e.g., in 2 Corinthians *passim*).

I think that careful thought is required with regard to what Paul means by **teach** (διδάσκω) in 1 Tim 2:12. The Greek verb, much like the English verb, has a fairly wide range of meaning. For instance, “nature” (φύσις) can be said to “teach” appropriateness (1 Cor 11:14), something it does not do in a classroom in front of seated students. Then there is the sense in which congregants can be said to be teaching one another through music (Col 3:16; note that the parallel passage [Eph 5:19] has “speaking” [λαλέω] in the equivalent position). In some passages the verb might have a specialized sense, “inform concerning the key points of Christianity,” “catechize” (e.g., Col 1:28; cf. the related noun “teaching” [διδάχη] in passages like Rom 6:17). At other times, the verb implies an intrinsic connection between the dispensing of instruction and the authority which lies behind it (1 Cor 4:17, 1 Tim 4:11). In the present case, the fact that Paul closely links διδάσκω with **hold mastery** (αυθεντεω; more on this word in the following paragraph) makes it highly probable that what Paul has in mind is the last-mentioned sense of διδάσκω, viz. teaching as an act of authority. By implication, there are some roles in which a woman can facilitate learning without holding a leadership position. Arguably, examples would include tutoring certain subjects (e.g., mathematics or Greek) or teaching college courses. Also, as already mentioned biblical teaching has no qualms about women serving in prophetic roles (cf. 22 Ki 22:14ff, 1 Cor 11:5). Possibly this is because the kinds of prophecies that occur in these cases are more descriptive, advisory, and encouraging than prescriptive, authoritative, and corrective.

The word translated **hold mastery** (αυθεντεω) in 1 Tim 2:12 seems to be quite a strong term, even referring in some instances to homicide. Obviously that is not what Paul is thinking of here, but that usage could give an idea of the flavor of this term. Now, one could argue on that basis that Paul forbids not women in authority, only women usurping or abusing authority. But in that case it is unclear why it is necessary for Paul to add **over a man** (ανδρος, the contextually appropriate form of ανηρ)—for Paul would not permit illegitimate

exercise of power over a woman! Moreover, in vv13-14 Paul argues, it seems to me, in a way that presupposes that he has said that women ought not to be leaders, not that women ought not to be conniving or domineering leaders. It is also to be noted that as the Greek language developed over time, the force of *αυθεντεω* was at some point to weaken considerably (cf. Moulton and Milligan *s.v.*). Possibly, then, Paul does not even mean *cruel* leadership here, just leadership in general. If so, this would explain why Paul, who reveled in teaching (v7, 1 Cor 14:1-5, etc.), is not afraid to link *αυθεντεω* with *διδασκω* (“to teach”). But it seems inferable from this text that Paul is prohibiting female leadership.

A legitimate question concerning this prohibition is whether it applies to church operations, to activities outside of the church, or both. That it obtains *at least* in church seems clear: This epistle, with its emphasis on proper teaching (1:3ff), its detailed description of pastoral qualifications and duties (3:1ff), and its statement that it intends to instruct concerning “the church of the living God” (3:15), is clearly concerned in a special way with the church; and there are also other passages that point in the same direction, such as 1 Cor 14:35, which prohibits women from directing the course of the church service, even if it is based on a desire to learn.

Whether the leadership limitation obtains *outside* the church is less clear. On the one hand, Paul will shortly (1 Tim 2:13-14) ground his prohibition in historical events that long predate Pentecost, though admittedly there is an important sense in which even Adam and Eve belong to the people of God; and it seems strange, in view of the imperative for male leadership in the church (1 Tim 3:1ff) and in the home (Col 3:18), to suppose that in society at large the situation is entirely different. On the other hand, there are examples of female leaders in civil society in biblical history (e.g., Jdg 4:4ff). I tend to think that it is preferable, where possible, for men to step up to the plate. Yet there is no place for insubordination to already-established authority (Rom 13:1), and still less for men to disparage women, who after all are God's creation (Gen 2:22); and there might well be exceptional cases in which a modern-day Deborah steps forward.

When in 1 Tim 2:12 Paul says **over a man** (again, *ανδρος* from *ανηρ*), he highlights the fact that gender relations are what is in view. This word can distinguish “adult male” from “young boy,” though in this connection it should be noted that in the ancient world functional adulthood tended to arrive sooner in a person's life (whether male or female; in fact, especially so in the latter case) than it does in the modern world. To my mind, an implication of this fact is that it is fully appropriate for a woman to teach young boys (e.g., in a public school setting).

The word **quiet** at the end of 12 is again *ησυχια*, discussed above (in the comments on v11).

In v13 Paul backs up his position by appealing not to his own opinion, to contemporary cultural sensibilities, to tradition, or to any potential for abuse of power by women (he is all too aware of the potential for abuse of power by men [Ac 20:29, 1 Tim 5:20, etc.], yet does not dispense with male leadership roles). Instead, Paul appeals to God's choice of sequence in creating the two genders. Adam of course was the first male and the first human being in history (Gen 2:17, 4:25), and Eve was the first woman and the second human being (Gen 2:22, 3:20). Eve was made to help Adam (Gen 2:18), not be his leader. Here it must be understood that to disparage the role of helper is to disparage Father (Ps 109:26), Son (Mk 10:45), and Holy Spirit (Jn 14:16). Nevertheless, God delegated a certain task to Adam (Gen 2:15), and gave to Eve the role of assisting Adam.

In 1 Tim 2:14 Paul adds to the decision of God the lesson of history. It was Eve who, hearing the serpent's words and believing them (Gen 3:6, 13), crossed the one boundary God had given to humanity (Gen 2:17). Adam, however, is not said to have been taken in by the serpent's words, only to have gone along with his wife's plan (Gen 3:6, 12). Apparently, he was more concerned with pleasing his wife than pleasing his God. Arguably, Adam's sin was greater than Eve's, in that he knew full well what he was walking into. But Paul's present concern is not with the fact that Eve sinned, but that she was **deceived**. Probably Paul does not mean to imply that in some fashion Eve's sin itself has forever restricted women from leadership. If the exclusion of women from leadership was due to Eve's sin, then the prior (v13) argument from creation would be superfluous. It seems instead that Paul is afraid that history will repeat itself: As Eve was deceived in the garden, so a woman in leadership over a church might be deceived. Exactly why, how, and to what extent women are vulnerable to deception is not spelled out in this passage. That said, it seems to me that this vulnerability has long been in evidence throughout history, for women are disproportionately those absorbed into, and all too often often by, cults (e.g., the mystery cults of the ancient Hellenistic world or the Jehovah's Witnesses of today). True, the high

rate of female participation in these religious quasi-societies is likely reflective of a greater level of spirituality in women; yet while men are often lazy and indifferent, women are sometimes poor judges of where true spiritual health is to be found. Perhaps I have read Paul wrongly here. But Paul does seem to say that a woman should not be an authority figure, at least in church (1 Tim 2:12); further, he seems to say that there are non-arbitrary reasons for this limitation (vv13-14). In this connection it might be well to agree with these words of Karen Jobes: “Unfortunately, the question of woman’s role in the church has been too narrowly focused [in modern times] on the question of ordination. In fact, relatively few Christians—either men or women—are heading for ordination [in any denomination], and so the discussion completely overlooks the reality of life for most members of the church... Judging from the state of this discussion, one would think that the church has no vision for the significance of a woman’s life in Christ other than motherhood or ordination” (229). On the contrary, Scripture “endows the laity of the church with... eternal purpose” (Jobes, 228). Both men and women down through history and to the present day enjoy all manner of gifting and opportunity from God, whether they hold any formal title or not.

Paul, though of course not aware of modern sensibilities, nevertheless does sense that women who are taking his words to heart might feel discouraged. Accordingly, in v15 Paul offers reassurance. Indeed, he seems to have had these words of reassurance in mind for some time, for in v14 he refers to Adam's wife not as “Eve” but as **the woman**, thus enabling him in our present verse to say **she will be saved** with reference to any and every Christian woman, not to Eve alone; it is important for Paul to offer his readers a sense of hope.

Specifically, God-centered, decent living with an acceptance of feminine distinctives is for women the path to a flourishing Christian life. The words **through childbirth** seem to be Paul's shorthand here (for related language from Paul, cf. 5:14, Tit 2:5) for what for most women is a specifically feminine way of life. Paul is of course fully aware that some women are called to singleness (1 Cor 7:7a, 9:5), but since that way of life was rare in his day he does not take the space here to address that subcategory specifically. Some see **through childbirth** (δια της τεκνογονίας) as signifying the birth of our savior Jesus, especially since the Greek could also be translated “through *the* childbirth.” But Jesus' birth signaled the salvation of women *and* men, and in this passage Paul is concerned with gender-specific matters. Others see here in these words a promise of safety in the process of giving birth, but that could hardly be a universal promise given tragic experiences to the contrary, and it seems unlike the God of all grace (1 Pet 5:10) to condition successful childbirth on faith, love, holiness, and self-control. Rather, Paul's reassurance is this: Contrary to the claims of some religions, ancient and modern, women can find salvation not by *ceasing to be* a woman, nor *despite being* a woman, but *as* a woman. Womanhood is not to be attacked but to be affirmed.

Of course, by adding **if she remains in faith, love, and holiness, with self-control**, Paul does not mean to say that doing good works earns salvation. Earlier in this same epistle (1:14), Paul ascribes God's salvation to “grace” (χαρις), which implies a gift, not remuneration; and his epistle to Titus, written under similar circumstances and covering much of the same ground, Paul states that we are “justified by his [that is, God's] grace” (3:7). What Paul means to say is that a nominal Christian will not be saved, only the Christian who by her godly lifestyle demonstrates that the Spirit of God dwells within her (Rom 8:1-14). (Extremely similar language appears in Col 1:23.)

The triad **faith, love, and holiness** is of course reminiscent of the faith-hope-love triad in 1 Cor 13:13. In fact, holiness and hope are not as different as they first appear, since the former, as a practical outworking of purity in daily life, is only done because one believes in and anchors one's life on the future vision of Christ (1 John 3:2-3). To this triad Paul adds **self-control**, also a tangible expression of a heavenward focus.

For the most part, none of these four things are complicated. Paul is not calling women to a life of constant, tortured introspection, or to the assembling of and dutiful checking-off of long lists of behavioral requirements. He is calling them to a simple life, holding on to a conviction that God, though at present unseen, is in reality fully present, and one day to be seen; showing kindness to others; exchanging the pure and lovely qualities of godliness for the dirty and harmful attributes of sinfulness; and restraining one's cravings rather than being ruled by impulses. More often than not, these qualities are principally observed by a woman’s own children, not by powerful rulers and foreign nations. These qualities are no less important for it; if anything, they are thereby made less ethereal and more practical, and thus fully in keeping with the aim of true Christian

teaching (1 Tim 1:5). The truest faith, purest love, most radiant holiness, and most admirable self-control is often to be found within the walls of the home.

Inasmuch as many have taken male leadership to excuse male domination, two points must be emphasized in light of Paul's teaching elsewhere: All Christians must affirm the equal worth in Christ of male and female (e.g., Gal 3:28); and no Christian man who verbally, physically, or sexually abuses his wife can be considered a member of God's Church in good standing (e.g., 1 Cor 5:11).

Translation (3:1-7)

Faithful is the saying: "If anyone yearns to be a superintendent, it is a noble work he desires." 2 But it is necessary for the superintendent to be irreproachable; a one-woman man; sober; self-controlled; respectable; hospitable; skilled at teaching; 3 not addicted to alcohol; not quick to start a fight; not eager for illegitimate monetary gain—but equitable; peaceable; free from the love of money; 4 administering his own household well, with his children in submission with all dignity 5 (but if one is at a loss as to how to administrate his own household, how will he care for God's church?); 6 not a new convert, so that he will not, having become haughty, fall into the judgment into which the devil fell; 7 but he must indeed have a good reputation with those outside [the Church], so that he will fall not into reproach, and into the devil's snare.

Comments (3:1-7)

Paul now shifts his attention to the administration of the church. As his segue, he again (cf. 1 Tim 1:15) cites a saying that was well-known in the early church, viz. **If anyone yearns to be superintendent, it is a noble work he desires** (3:1). I use the term "superintendent" to highlight the background of the Greek word (ἐπισκοπος); traditionally it is rendered as either "bishop" or as "overseer". Paul elsewhere (Tit 1:5, Eph 4:1; cf. 1 Pet 5:4) describes this office with the words "elder" (πρεσβυτερος) or a "pastor" (ποιμην, literally "shepherd"): notice that the "elders" in Ac 20:17 are themselves "superintendents" (Ac 20:28); and that Peter, a student of Paul's teaching (2 Pet 3:15-16), tells "elders" (1 Pet 5:1) to "shepherd the flock" (v2). The flux in terminology is probably due to the fact that the pastoral office was in the first century a new one (though drawing in some respects from earlier models), and consequently a specific term for it did not exist. Each of these words emphasizes a different aspect of the role. "Overseer" points to leadership (the verb form appears in Ac 6:3), protection (1 Pet 2:25), and attentiveness (Ac 20:28); "elder" to dignity (Pr 20:29), wisdom (Ps 119:100 assumes that as a rule, the aged are intelligent), and representation (often in the OT, the elders of the people would act as the people's representatives; cf. Ex 3:16, Lev 9:1, Josh 7:6, Ac 15:6 etc.); "pastor" to care (Lk 15:4), self-sacrifice (John 10:11), and nourishment (Ps 23:1-2). To be clear, in many modern denominations there are distinctions between these terms, but for the purposes of this commentary, "superintendent," "elder," and "pastor" are synonyms. This office was valued in the early church (**it is a noble work**), and Paul agrees with this positive valuation.

But, Paul says (1 Tim 3:2), there are important footnotes to this saying (οὐν is sometimes used "in a slightly adversative sense" [Moulton and Milligan s.v., though they do not cite this passage]). Not just *any* individual who desires the pastoral office is to have it. He must be a *qualified* individual, and Paul will now give some pointers on how to identify who is, and who is not, qualified. The list of qualifications which Paul gives in Tit 1:6ff is, though similar, not identical. So neither list is comprehensive; yet both lists are clearly intended to provide a sufficient picture of what is to be looked for.

Most of the qualifications are fairly self-explanatory. Still, a few matters call for comment.

The first item listed arguably encapsulates many of the others: The aspiring superintendent is to be **irreproachable** (1 Tim 3:2). No one is perfect, but he should have no credible or proven charges that heavily tarnish his reputation.

Very controversial is the meaning of the words **a one-woman man** (v2). This is a literal translation of the Greek, capturing what might be its ambiguity: Whether it forbids polygamy, unfaithfulness, a prior divorce, or being part of more than one marriage over the course of a lifetime is not entirely clear. Yet it must be noted that there is a Greek word for a woman married only once (μοναῖδος), and Paul could easily have coined a masculine equivalent. He probably means to ban from the pastorate at least those who are guilty of polygamy

and unfaithfulness. When it comes to divorce, the matter is not so clear. There are two sides to every story, so careful inquiry would be required in the case of a divorced man aspiring to pastoral office in order to determine whether the circumstances of the divorce would be disqualifying. But Paul's main point is that the pastor must be undeniably loyal to his wife. That is, if he has a wife: Probably being married is not a requirement, for Paul was not married (1 Cor 9:5). Similarly, having children (cf. 1 Tim 3:4-5) is not likely to be necessary. But for most men in the ancient world, marriage—and with it, in most cases, children—was the natural course of life, so rather than focus on atypical people, Paul directs his words most directly to the typical aspiring elder.

The third qualification is being **sober** (v2). Just like the English word, the Greek word (νηφαλεος) can mean either “not intoxicated” or “exhibiting the qualities of a person who is not intoxicated,” i.e. “sensible.” Since the sixth qualification forbids alcohol abuse, Paul surely means “sensible.”

In our modern, media-driven world, it seems to me that men often attract public attention precisely because of their *lack* of a **peaceable** (v3) disposition. This lack is often given a more positive name (“a strong personality,” “boldness,” or the like), but the fact is that God's people are to be, and to be led by, peacemakers (Mat 5:9). This was Paul's habitual frame of mind as well (2 Tim 2:25, 4:16, etc.).

Another qualification is that which forbids ordination to a **new convert** (v6). True enough, there is no firm dividing line between a new believer and an experienced one; and in many cases a man who begins to pastor soon after his conversion does go on to have a long and commendable period of service to the Church. Yet the danger of arrogance is real, and Paul's words of warning must be respected.

A final, general observation is this: The man described by Paul in this paragraph is not necessarily an extraordinary individual. He is a man of good character and a good reputation, who also possesses an aptitude for teaching and a desire to lead in the church. Paul expected that Titus would be able to find qualified men in each city in Crete (Tit 1:5), even with his dim view of Cretan culture (vv12-13). There is no clear example in the New Testament of a church led by a single elder—and this in a time when, to all appearances, most churches were small. Yet in many modern denominations and circles of independent churches, a prospective pastor is all but required to have one or more degrees from an esteemed university or seminary. This *de facto* requirement imposes a burden not found in Scripture; privileges intellectual knowledge over proven character; and in effect restricts the pastoral office to those of a certain socioeconomic class, thereby perpetuating racial disparities and power imbalances. Men who wish to be pastors must meet certain requirements, and that is the burden of Paul's present discussion. But the search is not for a superhero.

Translation (3:8-13)

Similarly, [it is necessary for] deacons [to be] respectable; not duplicitous; not devoted to large quantities of wine; not eager for illegitimate monetary gain; 9 holding the secret of the faith with a pure conscience. 10 And these [individuals] must be tested first, then may serve [as deacons], being blameless.

11 Similarly, women [must be] respectable; not slanderers; sober; faithful in all things.

12 Deacons must be one-woman men, leading [their] children well, and their own households [as well].

13 For those who have served well make for themselves a good standing and notable reputation in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.

Comments (3:8-13)

Paul turns from the pastorate to the diaconate (1 Tim 3:8). The qualifications are very similar.

The meaning of the Greek behind **not duplicitous** (μη διλογους) in v9 is a bit uncertain. It seems to refer to saying different things to different people, as opposed to holding up a consistent version of events to everyone.

The words **not devoted to large quantities of wine** (μη οινω πολλω προσεχοντας) probably do not refer to addiction in the clinical sense, but to undue investment of resources and time into such things. Those who are wrapped up in the finest things of this earth will not be prepared to invest in the things of the new earth. In any case, drunkenness is not something that should characterize Christians (Eph 5:18).

To say **the secret of the faith** (1 Tim 3:9) seems to be equivalent to “key Christian doctrine” (as in v16). The word here translated “secret” is often translated “mystery.” Although that English word ultimately derives from the Greek word used here (μυστηριον), such is misleading: As Louw and Nida (§28.77) point out, the

English word “refers to a secret which people have tried to uncover but which they have failed to understand,” while the Greek does not imply that the matter in question cannot be understood, only that it is not known by most. The English word “secret” comes much closer to conveying the Greek when it is considered that “secret” at times refers not to information that is suppressed and protected, but to something distinctive and non-instinctual (as when, e.g., a musician or an author is asked in a public forum, “What is the secret to your success?”). On the other hand, μυστηριον, to a much greater extent than “secret,” has religious overtones; indeed, it might tend to bring to mind some of the various ill-reputed cults of that day. Perhaps that association is why Paul adds “with a pure conscience,” viz. to clarify that he is not by using this word endorsing the frenzied and wicked behavior of many involved in those cults. But since Paul uses μυστηριον fairly often, without often seeming to feel a need to qualify it, a different explanation is preferable. Probably Paul adds these words to underscore that assent to a creed is not enough: Christianity must not only be in their heads and spoken on their lips, but in their hearts and imprinted on their hands (cf. Jm 1:23). There are aspects to the Christian faith that are distinctive to it and would not occur to people without specific instruction in them which need to be publicly heralded (v16).

The testing prescribed in v10 (δοκιμαζω) is a watchful examination to take place for a reasonable period of time in order to determine whether seeming fitness for the office of deacon is genuine, or merely a front that they put up.

v11 is controversial. I have attempted a literal translation with **women**, but it is not possible to be fully literal, since there is an ambiguity in Greek which English cannot capture: The Greek word for “wife” is the same word as the word for “woman” (γυνή). Hence some argue that the Greek here should be rendered “their wives,” and mean that what Paul is doing here is providing another, albeit indirect, qualification for prospective deacons, viz. that their wives also be individuals of honorable character. Such a qualification is not unreasonable, since it could be difficult for a deacon to maintain his role if his wife is an unbeliever or a rebellious Christian. Also, Paul in v12 again addresses himself to male deacons, so seeing v11 as part of the qualifications of the (exclusively) male deacon would entail continuity of discourse.

On the other hand, the transitional word “similarly” (οσαυτως) is unexpected if Paul is simply continuing his list of qualifications. Indeed, any continuation at all is somewhat unexpected following on the heels of v10. Also, for γυναικας (which is γυνή, inflected to fit the syntax of the passage) in the present context to mean “their wives,” one would expect the assistance of an article and pronoun (viz. τας γυναικας αυτων); or, instead of γυνή, the use of a less ambiguous term (such as γαμετη or συμβιος). It is also notable that Paul gave no qualifications for pastors' wives (vv1-7), a strange omission if there are requirements for deacons' wives. It seems, then, more natural to translate “women,” and understand Paul to be speaking of female deacons, especially in light of Rom 16:1. There a woman (Phoebe) is said to be a διακονος, and though many translations of Rom 16:1 render this word “servant,” such is very strained indeed: It seems unlikely that an early congregation would have a literal servant in its employ, while “deacon” fits what she is doing, viz. engaging in some mission (v2). This approach does not contradict Paul's prohibition in 1 Tim 2:12, for—as is evident in the very term (literally, “servant”) and in the rationale behind the diaconate (Ac 6:1ff)—the diaconate is an office of service, not leadership. The question, however, is not altogether clear-cut. Accordingly, denominational and other norms should be respected, and the matter must be discussed in an irenic manner.

As mentioned already, Paul's remarks in v12 are a bit unexpected. Perhaps these concerns did not occur to Paul initially as he wrote (or dictated) the letter, sexual purity and effective leadership in the home not being a preoccupation for Paul. Still, home life is important. When Paul says **and their households** after mentioning **children**, he is broadening the scope from children alone to children together with one's wife, as well as any servants, employees, work animals, etc. Paul does not expressly state that female deacons must be faithful to their husbands and effective in the home. To some extent he surely does expect them to do these things (cf. Tit 2:4), yet he feels no need here to state it, either in the interest of concision, or because he (unlike many in the ancient world) has a general confidence in the faithfulness of wives.

If one does well in the role (the Greek for **served** [διακονησαντες] is a participle related to the noun meaning “deacon” [διακονος]), one can expect **a good standing and a notable reputation** (v13). There is some uncertainty as to the translation “a notable reputation” (πολλην παρρησιαν); another possibility is “great

confidence,” referring to the deacons’ own confidence in their standing before God (for the thought, cf. 1 Jn 3:21), but the pairing with **a good standing** (βαθμον... καλον) suggests the translation given above. A good reputation is not something to be sought for its own sake (Mat 6:2, etc.), but it is, if merited, a good thing—particularly when those making the assessment are those of the household of God (cf. 1 Cor 6:3, 2 Cor 8:18, etc.), which is probably why Paul appends **in the faith that is in Christ Jesus**. Fame in the world might not come to the faithful deacon, but faith looks beyond the small confines of this present life to the boundless beauties of the world to come.

The conjunction (**For**) at the start of v13 (γαρ; in Greek this word never occurs first in its clause, and here, as is most often the case in the NT, occurs second in its clause) signals that what Paul says in v13 is in a sense the basis for what he has said in this paragraph (viz. vv8-12): A look at qualifications are in order, for as a rule the diaconate is to be filled by particularly commendable Christians. When Paul inserts the adverb **well** (καλως), he seems to acknowledge that there will be occasional disappointments, for along the way there will be some deacons whose life and ministry is sub par. Still, the tone and expectation stated here is positive.

By ending this paragraph with this statement, and particularly by using the word **good** (καλος, v13), Paul provides a verbal and conceptual link with v1 (for the word translated “noble” there is also καλος). In this way he provides a positive assessment of both offices, and rounds out his discussion of the offices of the church.

Paul says nothing concerning apostles, evangelists, or other roles. There are various ways in which the absence of such discussion could be understood, but it is in any case a notable absence, and I think it is safe to say that ecclesiastical theory and practice should, whatever stance is taken on other matters, emphasize the full and proper use of the offices of pastor and deacon.

Translation (3:14-16)

These things I write to you, hoping to come to you quickly, 15 but if I am delayed, [I write these things to you] that you may know how it is necessary for one to conduct oneself in the house of God, which is the Church of the living God, a pillar and buttress of the truth. 16 And with common agreement, great is the secret of piety:

*“God was revealed in flesh,
vindicated in the Spirit,
seen by angels,
proclaimed among the nations,
believed in the world,
taken up in glory.”*

Comments (3:14-16)

Here, approximately in the middle of his letter, Paul reiterates (cf. 1 Tim 1:3-4) his purpose in writing to Timothy, viz. to clarify how church life is to unfold (3:14a, 15b). Paul would prefer to convey this information face-to-face (v14b; cf. 2 Jn 12, 3 Jn 13-14), but, given the exigencies of ancient travel (1 Tim 3:15a), he has used the medium of letter-writing to meet the immediate need (Paul takes a similar approach in 1 Cor 11:34). In the modern world, email, video-conferencing platforms, and the like ought not to replace regular face-to-face communication where such is possible; nevertheless, we should be thankful for and make good use of such technologies in the service of the Church and its mission.

For someone as steeped in biblical literature as Paul to say **the house of God** (1 Tim 3:15) is tantamount to saying “the Temple,” the place for the worship of the one true God built in the days of Solomon and rebuilt in the days of Ezra. This identification of the Temple as **the Church** is breathtaking: The locus for God’s worship has been transferred from the ancient and magnificent structure (still standing, of course, as Paul writes this epistle) in Jerusalem, the capital of the Jewish state (under Roman occupation, to be sure) to an ethnically mixed (Eph 2:11-14), largely poor and unimpressive (1 Cor 1:26) people scattered across the globe (Col 1:6), the Church.

This Church belongs to **the living God**. In the ESV this phrase occurs elsewhere in Dt 5:26, Josh 3:10, 1 Sam 17:26, v36, 2 Ki 19:4, v16, Ps 42:2, 84:2, Isa 37:4, v17, Jer 10:10, 23:36, Dan 6:20, v26, Hos 1:10, Matt 16:16, 26:63, Rom 9:26, 2 Co. 3:3, 6:16, 1 Tim 4:10, Heb 3:12, 9:14, 10:31, 12:22, and Rev 7:2. Most of these

passages have in common an emphasis on God's absolute power or his connection to the Temple. Since the Temple has just been invoked, it is probably the latter association that principally drives Paul's use of **the living God** here (though Hos 1:10 in particular might be looming large in Paul's mind at this point). The sturdiness and magnificence of the Temple leads naturally to a metaphor: The Church is a **pillar** and a **buttress** (both of these being architectural means for supporting the roof of a great structure). Unimpressive as most of its members are by the standards of the world, the Church is nevertheless a (or possibly "the"; the Greek is ambiguous on this point) means by which God maintains **the truth** in the darkness-engulfed world (cf. 2 Cor 4:4). Truth was to a significant extent an interest to both Greek thinkers (one can readily cite names such as Herodotus and Plato), who greatly influenced the Roman world; and to Jewish thinkers of the intertestamental period (e.g., 1 Esdras 4:38-40), whose work obviously influenced the intellectual milieu of the first century Jews and proselytes. But the Church is where truth finds its defense. The Church as an institution is not infallible—Paul has already indicated in this very epistle (1:4, etc.) that poor teaching does indeed find its way into the Church, and that intentionality is required to reverse its effects (1:3, etc.)—but in and through the Church, where the God of the Temple meets with his people, truth is found and promulgated.

And indeed, what is promulgated in and by the Church (**with common agreement**) is **great** (v16). Paul is fairly sparing in his use of this adjective (in Greek, *μεγας*), using it only a handful of times elsewhere in his letters (Rom 9:2, 1 Cor 9:11, 16:9, 2 Cor 11:15, Eph 5:32, 1 Tim 6:6, 2 Tim 2:20, Tit 2:13). Of these, Eph 5:32 is especially significant, since the word *μυστηριον* is also used there (**secret**; on this word, see the comments above on 1 Tim 3:9); marriage and the events of the life of Christ are things which, each in their way, bear a cosmic significance. In Eph 5:32 the NIV renders *μεγα* as "profound," a fitting translation. The label Paul uses in our present verse for the content of the Church-buttressed truth is **the secret of piety**. The term **piety** (*ευσεβεια*) speaks of an appropriate reverence for God, manifested both in inward attitude and in outward actions. The attitudinal connotation is probably uppermost in Paul's mind, given the awe in which Paul would certainly insist that the God of the Temple—or rather, the God of the Church—ought to be held; but of course an attitude, when thoroughly inculcated, will inevitably overflow into action. The exact relationship between **secret** and **piety** here is a bit unclear, since the Greek genitive case in which **piety** is cast here (reflected in the translation by the presence of the word "of" in front of "piety") is tremendously variable. Among the most fundamental ideas conveyed in the genitive is "the (notional) domain that something belongs to" (von Siebenthal §158a, p234), so what is safest is to say is that the **secret** spoken of finds its home in the realm of piety, i.e. genuine Christian worship.

In order to unfold the content of this **great** Christian **secret**, Paul in the remainder of v16 seemingly quotes an early Christian statement of faith. That **God was revealed in flesh**, etc. is a creed (of sorts; not all elements of later creeds can necessarily be projected back onto this passage) is suggested by **with common agreement** (*ομολογουμεως*), invoking the assent of the Church as a whole. It is also possible that what follows is Paul's spur-of-the-moment composition, but if it is, Paul is altogether confident that the whole Church would agree with it. Some scholars consider these lines as an early hymn, but the lines do not seem to conform to poetic norms of the day. That said, they do exhibit careful artistry, though not all of it survives the translation process. Even those who do not read Greek can gain a measure of appreciation for this artistry by taking a look at it in its original language:

θεος εφανερωθη εν σαρκι
εδικαιωθη εν πνευματι
ωφθη αγγελοις
εκηρυχθη εν εθνεσιν
επιστευθη εν κοσμω
ανεληφθη εν δοξη

Here are the six lines of the creed, translated and commented upon:

God was revealed in flesh: Before discussing this line, a preliminary matter must be addressed: Not all manuscripts and other sources of information on the exact text of the Greek New Testament agree on whether *θεος* ("God"), *ος* ("who," a grammatically masculine relative pronoun), or *ο* ("which," a grammatically neuter relative pronoun) kicks off this first line of the creed. It should be emphasized at the outset that while the reading

θεός most directly indicates Jesus' divinity, the reading ος and ο ultimately can only fairly be understood as referring to him (the latter being grammatically neuter because the antecedent is presumably the neuter μυστηριον, which on this reading is a circumlocution for Jesus as a person long hidden but now revealed to and in the Church), and since the line goes on to say that Jesus **was revealed in flesh**, an existence prior to his human existence is obviously implied. Still, it is a worthy effort to inquire concerning the exact verbiage of this Scripture. Most scholars today hold that ος is original, partly on account of the testimony of certain notable manuscripts; and partly on account of the fact that ος is the most difficult reading, the logic being that scribes would tend to intervene in the interest of clarity—in this case either turning a relative pronoun (ος) with a missing antecedent either into one *with* an antecedent (ο; the antecedent is, as already mentioned, presumably μυστηριον) or into a grammatical *subject* (θεός). I feel it necessary to dissent respectfully from this opinion. It is beyond the scope of this commentary to challenge the primacy of the manuscripts that attest ος, except to note that virtually no one today would accept the testimony of these manuscripts in *every* case. Preference for difficult readings, meanwhile, has some merit; yet it is indisputable that anyone attempting to copy a lengthy text by hand is liable to err, and frequently to err in ways that make a passage *more*, not less, difficult to understand. Such is all the more the case where visual or other factors tend to promote error. In this connection, it must be noted that in many early manuscripts of the New Testament the word θεός was written, for reasons of reverence, without the middle two letters and with a bar over the top of the word. If that bar was overlooked (perhaps it was faded, or it was crowded into the line of text running above this word), and if the bar of the letter *Theta* was overlooked (perhaps it too was faded, or simply went unnoticed due to fatigue or distraction), the result would look like the word ος. But as this form lacks an antecedent (von Siebenthal §289g, p545 notes, with reference to the present verse, that sometimes a relative pronoun can forgo a grammatical antecedent, but the first word of a creed seems to be an odd place for this usage), one or more well-meaning scribes, trying to correct what (rightly or wrongly) seemed to them a mistake, “corrected” the masculine form to a neuter one (ο). The difficulty is not really, I think, solved, for it seems to me that **the secret** is used in the same sense as in v9 (viz. as the distinctive content of Christianity), and as a restatement of **the truth** in v15 (cf. 4:1, where “the faith” might be a resumption of this same concept); saying **the secret**, then, cannot quite be equivalent to saying “Jesus Christ,” and the passage loses some of its coherence. Cycling back to ος, some argue that Paul has quoted only *part* of the creed, leaving out the part that made explicit use of the name of Jesus. But it seems strange to me that Paul would quote a creed at such length, yet leave out precisely that portion without which the remainder makes no sense. Also, the readings ος and ο might have been influenced by Col 1:27 (where the manuscripts vacillate between ος and ο), in which passage μυστηριον is also near a slightly puzzling relative pronoun (however, “Christ in you” in that passage is probably the definition not of μυστηριον but of “the richness of the glory which belongs to the μυστηριον,” since μυστηριον is there equivalent to the gospel message [cf. Col 1:25-26]). In short, the reading θεός in 1 Tim 3:16 makes better sense of the passage and better explains the existence of the alternative readings than do ος or ο; it is also amply attested in the manuscripts.

As for the meaning of the line **God was revealed in flesh**, God the Son became a human. The creed is quite direct here in referring to Jesus as **God** (θεός), but not without precedent (e.g., Isa 9:6). The Greek word behind **was revealed** (φανερω) is quite a loaded one: It speaks of something coming to light, sometimes in a fairly general sense, but often in the sense of becoming famous or being recognized in all of its profound significance. Furthermore, a related noun (viz. επιφανης) was sometimes used in pagan literature to refer to certain supposed visits of the gods to the world of mortals. This was the name of the violent and blasphemous king who, generations before Paul, wrought devastation and provoked insurrection in Israel (Epiphanes; 1 Maccabees 1:10, etc.). The sphere or manner in which this revelation took place was **in flesh** (εν σαρκι). This noun has a wide range of uses, among them reference to corporeal mortality; and the tacit contrast with **God** in this line makes it clear that this is indeed the idea here. The display of God's fame related in this line is that of Jesus assuming human form.

vindicated in the Spirit: What precisely lies behind this line of the creed is not entirely clear; the only other place in the New Testament where the verb “vindicate” (δικαιωω) occurs very close to the noun “Spirit” (πνευμα) is 1 Cor 6:11, which shows the close partnership of Son and Spirit in salvation history, but otherwise sheds little light on the present passage. Now, **in the Spirit** (εν πνευματι, the latter word being contextual form

of πνεῦμα) could also be rendered “in spirit” or “in [his] spirit,” since in ancient times the Greek alphabet made no distinction between uppercase and lowercase letters. Indeed, “flesh” and “Spirit” are frequently contrasted in the New Testament. Here, however, there is no contrast between these things, for it is not a *bad* thing that Jesus **was revealed in flesh**. Moreover, it seems peculiar to say that Jesus' vindication extended to his spiritual life, as if his material existence as a human was somehow morally flawed. It seems much more coherent, and much more in keeping with the profundity of the creed as a whole, to see here a reference to the Holy Spirit. Perhaps the Spirit's role at Jesus' baptism (Mat 3:16), the angelic announcement that the Holy Spirit would empower Mary's virginal conception of Jesus (Lk 1:35), prophecies concerning the Spirit's uniquely prominent role in Christ's life (Isa 11:2, 48:16), or the role of the Spirit in Jesus' resurrection (Rom 8:11) are the key texts and events; in truth, the author(s) of the creed might be reflecting an awareness of the cumulative effect of all these things, whether or not each of these specific passages was at the forefront. The Spirit whose presence over the ancient waters (Gen 1:2) prepared the way for the Son's creation of all (Col 1:16) also uttered his inerrant testimony (Jn 15:26) concerning Christ.

seen by angels: There is debate as to whether the Greek here (ωφθη ἀγγελοις) means “seen by angels” or “appeared to angels.” Without attempting to delve into the details here, I contend that the former meaning is possible (cf. Lk 23:15 for the grammatical construction), and somewhat probable (for all the other verbs in this creed are passive in sense). If I am wrong about this, the sense might be that Jesus' life and ministry was observed by and relevant for not the human world alone, but also the angelic realm; or the sense might be that in some sense Christ presented himself after his sacrifice victorious to the angelic hosts (Laurence Brown, personal communication). If, on the other hand, my understanding is correct, the intent evidently is to further validate the ministry of Jesus, for the prophecy of the Old Testament (Ps 91:11) was amply confirmed (Mk 1:13, Lk 22:43, 24:23, etc.). In any case, the divine, human, and angelic realms all converge on the person of Jesus (cf. Jn 1:51).

proclaimed among the nations: Jesus, and his significance, was publicly announced not only within the nation of Israel, but beyond it as well. Here an ambiguity of the Greek, which it inherits from Hebrew usage (גוי) must be mentioned: “Nation” (ἐθνός) can also mean “gentile,” and in many cases there is in fact no meaningful distinction between the two. Since the Assyrian destruction of northern Israel (2 Ki 17:5ff), there had only been *one* Jewish nation, so the nations beyond Israel were all essentially Gentile in racial composition. Thus, for Jesus to be **proclaimed** outside the one nation of Israel is for him to be preached to the Gentiles as well as to the Jews. Perhaps this line of the creed was included, in part at least, as a gentle rebuke of wrongheadedly judeo-centric theological systems all too prevalent in the early days of the Church (e.g., Ac 11:19, 15:1). This background might explain the apparently non-chronological nature of the creed, for while the first line of the creed refers to the Incarnation, and the last to the Ascension, the present line does not refer to events in between those two points of the timeline. On the other hand, perhaps the author(s) simply felt no need to organize their material chronologically. In any case, while Jesus' earthly ministry did have immediate effects on the Gentile world (e.g., Mk 7:24ff, Lk 7:2ff), his work at that time was focused in a special way on the Jewish people (Mat 10:5, 15:24; cf. Rom 1:16). But Jesus, echoing earlier prophecies (cf., e.g., Isa 2:2, 56:3) commanded that at the proper time his disciples should reach all the nations (Mat 28:19, Ac 1:8). Those who were eyewitnesses of Jesus made a good start to this task (Mk 16:20, Rom 15:19, Col 1:6), and the Church has ever since, if at times faltering, continued the work (Mk 13:10, Rev 7:9). The message of Jesus, though originating in a particular ethnicity and culture, quickly and irrevocably spread to a dazzling diversity of races, languages, political structures, and ways of life. For nothing is more cross-cultural, and nothing is more basic to human flourishing, than the gospel.

believed in the world: Many people have embraced Jesus' offer of salvation. This line nicely complements the previous one, for not only was the gospel proclaimed, but also accepted (cf. Isa 55:10-11). Those whom the Lord appoints to eternal life do not reject Christ, but believe (cf. Ac 13:48). And the scope of this activity is broad: The geographic diversity of those who have become Christians is so great that the area in which belief in Christ has obtained is best characterized as **the world**. “The earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea” (Isa 11:9).

taken up in glory: When Jesus had completed his lowly work on the earth, he gloriously ascended to sit at the right hand of the Father. The verb here (ἀναλαμβάνω) is in a few other verses used in reference to the Ascension (Mk 16:19, Ac 1:2, v11, v22). (The contextual form is either ἀνεληφθῇ or ἀνελημφθῇ; this variation

in spelling does not affect the meaning and need not detain us here.) The word **glory** (δοξα) is possibly used, directly or indirectly, of the Ascension in a few places (Lk 24:26, Jn 17:5, Heb 2:7, 1 Pet 1:21); without a doubt, the fact of the Ascension and the dispensing of glory are closely associated concepts (cf. Isa 53:10-12, Eph 1:20-21, Phil 2:9). The Ascension is, of course, not the termination of Jesus' activities, for from his exalted position in heaven he continues to accomplish the salvation of his elect (Mk 16:20, Ac 18:10), to intercede on behalf of his saints (Mat 28:20, Heb 7:25), and to prepare a place for his children (Jn 14:2); and from there he will one day return to render vindication to the righteous and justice to the wicked (Mat 25:31ff, Rev 22:12). Yet insofar as the Ascension demonstrated the Father's just acceptance of Christ's atoning work and Jesus' just assumption of kingly duties over all humanity, the Ascension is a fitting capstone for his earthly life and work, and a high point on which to bring this beautiful creed to an end.

There is endless opportunity for reflection here. I will mention a few points.

First, the christology of the early Church was high. That is to say, while the finer points of the doctrine of Christ took time for the Church to work out—if indeed they *have* been sufficiently worked out—worship of Jesus sprang more or less immediately and more or less naturally from the hearts of the earliest members of the Church (cf. Mat 28:17). Jesus was not only thanked for what he had done, not only held up as in important respects a model to emulate—he was worshiped in his divinity. The modern Church must maintain and advance this reverence for Jesus.

Second, while the centrality of Jesus in the life of the Church cannot be overestimated, it can in some ways be misjudged. “The Trinity has been increasingly divorced from the life and worship of the church. For the overwhelming majority of Western Christians, it is hardly an exaggeration to say that it is considered more a mathematical conundrum than a vital matter of everyday faith and worship” (Letham 290). The creed affirmed by Paul is, by contrast, deeply Trinitarian: Jesus' life and work was **vindicated by the Spirit**, and it is self-evidently the Father to whose side Jesus was **taken up in glory**. Jesus, then, though the key figure around which the arc of biblical narrative revolves, is to be understood in communion and in concerted action with the Father and the Spirit. The modern Church must recover or continue in Trinitarian worship and life.

Third, there is, as we have seen, a wealth of deeply considered Old Testament material standing in the background of this creed. Too often the Old Testament is demeaned, ignored, or studied in a manner which never quite gets around to affirming Christ as the fulfillment of that corpus. The modern Church must study the pages of the Old Testament with eyes continually prepared to see glimpses of Jesus.

By way of summary, v16 might be paraphrased thus: “Yes, the key insight associated with Christian reverence for God is, as the whole Church affirms, something profound indeed: God became man, enjoyed the Holy Spirit's corroborating testimony, worked with angelic support, achieved recognition among Jews and Gentiles alike, became an object of faith across the earth, and ascended to a state of glory at the Father's side.”

Translation (4:1-5)

But the Spirit expressly says that in the latter times certain people will reject the faith, paying attention to deceptive spirits and demonic teachings, 2 hypocritically speaking untruths, have been seared in their own consciences, 3 forbidding marriage, [telling others] to keep a distance from foods—things which God created for participation with thanksgiving by those who are believers and who know the truth. 4 For every creation of God is good, and nothing is to be rejected [as impure], when it is received with thanksgiving, 5 for it is sanctified by the word of God and the gathering [of the church].

Comments (4:1-5)

By **expressly** (4:1) Paul might be referring to a specific passage (cf. Dan 12:4, where the Masoretic הדעת, “knowledge,” is probably a scribal error for הרעה, “evil,” a reading preserved in the Old Greek translation; Mat 24:12; Ac 20:30; 2 Thes 2:3ff; 2 Pet 2:1), but since no one passage of Scripture matches this one exactly (and some might have been written only after 1 Timothy was), it seems more likely that Paul refers to some prophecy from the Holy Spirit given in the early days of the Church. (If that prophecy was not originally a part of Scripture, however, its presence here in 1 Timothy means that from *our* vantage point, it *is* in fact Scripture.) It is at any rate clear from the passages just cited that warnings about worsening conditions and false teachers were

freely circulating in the early Church. The phrase **the latter times** does not refer *as such* to the time immediately before the Second Coming; rather, all of history after the Ascension of Christ, however prolonged, is the final phase of God's war with the Serpent (1 Cor 10:11, Heb 1:2, 9:26). In light of this verse, we ought not to be surprised if and when we see professing Christians—even, if not especially, pastors and other high-profile individuals—repudiate, explicitly or by their actions, the Christian faith.

Few knowingly leap into destructive absurdities, so the demonic spirits who provide the theoretical basis for defections from genuine Christianity cloak their actions in deception. Nowadays, a prime example of this destructive deception would be gender confusion. Many today are lured into acceptance of homosexual activity and of attempts to alter one's gender by being made to see such things as defending out-groups against discrimination. Yet, beneath the laudable facade (and indeed, what those engaged in homosexuality and transgenderism need is love, not ridicule, deprivation of voting rights, or other forms of brutality), what is actually happening when human sexuality is misused or marred is ultimately self-destructive.

But defection from Christian doctrine is not merely a matter of having been misled. It comes about in a context of persistent duplicity towards others and persistent grievances of one's own conscience (v2; cf. Eph 4:30). Hence the need for sincerity (cf. 1:5, 3:8) and sanctification (cf. 1:5, 4:16).

Paul in v3 cites what seems to have been his most pressing concern for the Ephesians (cf. 1:4, vv6-7), viz. a misplaced, and ignorantly executed, interest in matters of Law. Comparison with some of the above-mentioned passages concerning the last days suggests that the issues raised here in v3 are examples of possible sins, not a comprehensive list. Indeed, in 2 Tim 3:1ff Paul addresses this matter at greater length, and provides a fuller list of sinful characteristics. In other words, forms of legalism are a symptom of sinful thinking, but not the only possible symptom.

Precisely why marriage would have been forbidden by these misled teachers is not entirely clear; possibly there was a mistaken notion that sex is in every case less than holy (cf. 1 Cor 7:1ff). The reason for food restrictions is not far to seek, since the Law of Moses contained many dietary regulations, and legalism of various kinds was a constant danger in the early Church. Moreover, distinctives in food consumption are powerful resources in building and maintaining an identity, and therefore bear great emotional weight. But God created marriage (Paul refers to heterosexual marriage, not homosexual “marriage”; cf. 1 Cor 6:6, etc.) and food, and for this institution and for these sources of nourishment believers ought to display gratitude, not aversion.

In many ways 1 Tim 4:4 is a restatement of v3, but the point made in v3 certainly bears repeating. For much of Church history marriage, or at least sex, has been held in disrepute among Christians; and to this day, questions about the lawfulness of certain foods (pork in particular) linger in the minds of many. But regulations of this kind are no longer needed, nor even beneficial. Paul does not give a detailed explanation of these matters here, perhaps because such would be unnecessary for Timothy. Elsewhere he provides more detail (e.g., Gal 3:19ff, Col 2:13ff).

Yet—to take food as an example of a larger principle—it is not quite correct to say that *all* food in *all* circumstances is to be freely consumed by *everyone*. (Some people have food allergies or other reasons not to eat certain things, but that fact is obvious, and does not sidetrack Paul here.) Paul points in the latter part of 1 Tim 4:4 to a matter that goes beyond bodily health and well-being in its significance: If a person cannot partake **with thanksgiving**, he or she should not partake at all. This might be a way of saying that if a person is going to be sullen about God's gracious provision, he or she might as well abstain. In light of the sanctification language used in v5, however, Paul probably means to address the situation where a person cannot be thankful because he or she does not in fact believe that the food is holy. To partake in a certain food with the belief that that food is displeasing to God—even if that belief is unfounded—would be sinful, for God's (perceived) standards would then have been rated as less important than personal preference or peer pressure. (Paul develops this theme at greater length in Rom 14:1ff.)

In defense of freedom in these matters, Paul has twice (1 Tim 4:3 and v4) cited God's having created everything; now (v5) he adds an additional consideration, viz. the sanctification of **the word of God and the gathering [of the church]**. (This verse is reminiscent of 1 Cor 7:14, for there the same verb “sanctify” (αγιαζω) is used of one person or thing somehow infusing another with a kind of holiness.) Now, sanctification is in the New Testament often used with reference to moral uprightness in the thought life and to outward speech and

behavior. But there another (related but distinct) usage, viz. of conformity to those rituals by which a person or object is rendered fit for God's use, especially being part of or being in the presence of the Temple (as a few examples, see Ex 13:2, Lev 8:10, and Num 5:9; in all of these passages the ancient Greek translations render the Hebrew root שָׁפַךְ with ἁγιαζω). This seems to be the usage of ἁγιαζω here in our verse, granting that for Paul the significance of the Temple is to be found now in the Church (see the comments on 3:15 above).

The exact signification of these two terms is a bit difficult to determine. The term **word** (λογος) certainly can (as in modern English) be equivalent to “the Bible” (as mentioned above in another connection, there was in Paul's day no distinction between uppercase and lowercase letters), but it does not bear this sense in every instance; it can refer to any declaration of God. For example, in Col 1:25 it refers to the content of the gospel (which is the capstone of the Bible, to be sure, but not the same thing as the Bible itself). So Paul might be saying that the Bible sanctifies food, or that God's declaration does. This is admittedly a fine distinction (the Bible is authoritative because it is spoken by God), but there might be value in it. For instance, depending on when the book of Mark was published, Paul might be referring to Christ's words in Mk 7:15 as Scripture; if that book has not yet been published as Paul writes this epistle (or a copy of it has not yet reached his hands), he might be referring to oral reports of what Jesus said. It is striking that, to my knowledge, there is not a particularly clear Old Testament prophecy concerning the cessation of dietary laws, nor much discussion of these points in the earliest of the New Testament epistles; there are, however, statements of Christ to this effect. Accordingly, I think that Paul is referring to God's declaration, not to the Bible as such.

As for **presence** (εντευξις), the word is typically translated “prayer.” If one understands εντευξις in that sense, questions arise concerning whose prayer (the one about to eat, or Jesus) attracts Paul's notice.

As for the first possibility, the idea would apparently be that the prayer of the person about to eat brings God's blessing upon the food is part of what gives it its sanctified character. Though there is certainly precedent for speaking to God before a meal (e.g., Mat 14:19), this approach to the present verse labors under three difficulties. First, the word εντευξις (“petition”) seems a strong term to use before one eats, though perhaps I misjudge either the force of the Greek word or the significance of food. Second, if Paul is requiring Christians to pray anytime they are about to eat, it could be argued that he is returning with the left hand what he takes away with the right: That is, he leaves Christians constantly to wonder whether they remembered to pray, or whether they prayed appropriately, or whether or not the size or nature of food or drink in fact required a prayer. Such would, it seems to me, incite a kind of introspection and attention to the letter of the law that the fullness of Christ ought to have taken away. Third, the context suggests that Paul is not speaking only of food, but also of marriage, and of many other aspects of life that certain false teachers wrongly attempt to restrict; this being the case, it is difficult to identify all of life's activities which require prayer for them to be legitimate.

As mentioned, the second possibility is that the prayer is that of Jesus, when he said of all his followers, “Sanctify [ἁγιαζω] them in your truth [αληθεια, the same word translated “truth” in 1 Tim 4:3]; your word [λογος] is truth” (Jn 17:17). In fulfillment of this petition, believers are free from the constant threat of pollution, and are free to walk by the Spirit (cf. Rom 8:2). But it is not clear to me whether these verbal parallels constitute sufficient grounds for insisting that Paul had precisely *this* prayer in mind.

My preferred, though loosely held, interpretation is that εντευξις denotes instead a *gathering*—that is, the coming-together of God's people in a given place. The Greek word speaks of an encounter wherein two or more people, or indeed a significant crowd, whether by agreement or happenstance, are in one another's presence and have a conversation or other significant form of interaction. Paul has recently (1 Tim 3:15) linked the people of God to the Temple, such that where the Church is, there God is. Paul's logic, then, might be that since God dwells among his people with all the radiance of his former enthronement in the Temple, the very fact that Christians are partaking of a food or other such item imparts a certain holiness to it. The analysis I have offered of εντευξις here and of Paul's logic has certain advantages. First, it is I think consonant with his approach in 1 Cor 7:14, where, making use of similar keywords, Paul indicates that the holiness granted to the Christian woman in some sense extends its beneficial effects to her unbelieving husband and children. Second, this analysis also reflects the fact that in the New Testament questions concerning food and related matters surface most acutely not in the privacy of the home, but where there is a gathering of some kind. For instance, it was the pressures and difficulties of church gatherings that led Peter wrongly to withdraw from fellowship with Gentile

Christians (Gal 2:11ff; cf. also 1 Cor 10:27ff, 11:17ff, etc.). This association between gathering and difficulties over what is and is not permitted no doubt stem in part from the prominence of shared meals in the early Church (Ac 2:42, Jude 12, etc.); in part from the power of peer pressure; and in part from the large degree to which such things, food not least, contribute to one's sense of social place and standing. Third and finally, this analysis of our present verse keeps the focus on God's actions, rather than on our actions: Just as it is God who created everything (1 Tim 4:3-4), so his presence among his people imparts a holiness to the things in which that people gratefully partakes, all to his glory (1 Cor 10:31).

Translation (4:6-7a)

In teaching these things to the brothers and sisters you will be a good servant of Jesus Christ, having been reared in the matters of faith and of the noble teaching which you have followed; 7 but decline [to participate in] profane fables of the kind elderly women are known for.

Comments (4:6-7a)

The rather complicated syntax of this section, though strange in English, is not odd in ancient Greek. The passage might be paraphrased thus: “You will serve Jesus Christ well when you instruct the church on everything I've reviewed in this letter. You're well-prepared for this, Timothy—you were raised in the Christian faith, and have spent your life involved in it yourself. But do make sure to stay away from ungodly and gossipy tall tales.”

By **these things** (1 Tim 4:6), Paul probably refers not only to the Christian freedoms sketched in 4:3, but to everything he had said before. Especially to be avoided are **fables** (v7), the same term used in 1:4; this passage is in part a recap of the epistle as a whole.

In Greek **the brothers and sisters** (1 Tim 4:6) is only one noun (τοις ἀδελφοις). However, this noun (the lexical form of which is ἀδελφος) can, when plural, refer to siblings of either gender. That latter sense is probably what Paul intends to be understood here, since Paul will later (5:1-2) take for granted that Timothy will be interacting as much with women as with men, though in the literary norms of the time it was generally not necessary to state clearly when both genders were in view.

The words **having been reared** probably allude to the fact that Timothy was taught the truths of Christianity from his childhood (cf. 2 Tim 1:5, 3:15). This must have been remarkable to Paul, who encountered Christianity only as an adult, and who for many years knew few people who had known Christ as a child. Similarly Peter, who spent several years in Jesus' company, expresses amazement at those who believe despite never having seen Jesus face-to-face (1 Pet 1:8). As stirring as the testimony of a man or woman saved later in life is, there is nothing to be embarrassed about in the case of a person with one or more Christian parents or caregivers whose faith, and education in the faith, began early in life. Of course, a parent's profession is not enough; the child herself or himself must also believe, and in larger or smaller ways give evidence of her or his salvation (**which you have followed**).

There is some ambiguity in the Greek behind **faith**, which could also be translated “the faith” (της πιστεως). The meaning could either be faith as an embrace of things not seen (cf. Heb 11:1), or faith as the doctrine and lifestyle inherent in Christianity. I lean towards the former (as reflected in the translation given above), since otherwise adding **and the teaching** would be redundant. Yet perhaps rather than being redundant, that addition is emphatic. It does not make much difference whichever approach one takes.

To serve well in the Church, Timothy not only needs to teach certain practices (v6), but also to avoid listening to others (v7a). The word **profane** signals the large distance that stands between the myths that circulate and the truths from and about the holy God. In saying **fables that elderly women are known for**, Paul has nothing against elderly women: He will go on in this same epistle (5:3ff) to take careful measures to respect the capabilities of women and to honor the conscientious among elderly women. But it is a fact of human experience that often elderly women engage in and spread baseless—and at times, scandalous—speculation. These things are not helpful (cf. 1:4). A comparison can be made between false teaching and the junk food so prevalent in the modern world: Candy might taste better than vegetables, but fails to provide the nutrition that the body really needs to thrive, and brings with it much that is detrimental.

Translation (4:7b-10)

But discipline yourself for piety. 8 For bodily discipline benefits [only] a little, but “piety is beneficial for everything, having the promise of life [both] now and in the coming [life].” 9 Faithful is the statement, and worthy of all acceptance. 10 For in pursuit of this goal we both labor and suffer reproach, for we have placed our hope in the living God, who is a savior of all people, especially of believers.

Comments (4:7b-10)

A life of godliness requires intentionality and effort (4:7b). For the purposes of illustration, it can be noticed that the English word “gym” derives from the Greek word for **discipline** (γυμναζω) here. More to the point, this Greek word does signify all manner of intensive training, especially for sporting events. If some people can conjure up the self-discipline to hit the gym regularly, all the more should they screw up the courage to pray in the Spirit, meditate on the Word, care for the poor, discipline the nations, and otherwise live a life of piety.

Developing this metaphor, Paul notes that **bodily discipline benefits [only] a little**, and then goes on to quote another “faithful statement” circulating in the early church (cf. 1:15, 3:1, v16) to the effect that the benefits of a godly life are both immediate *and* eternal. Now, Paul does not say that exercise is of *no* value, only *limited* value. Exercise is helpful and commendable—not least for pastors, much of whose work is taken up with verbal communication, not manual labor. But however healthy one's body is, the present life will come to an end all too soon (Jm 4:14).

In 1 Tim 4:9, Paul states his agreement (cf. the notes on 1:15) with a certain statement. It is a bit uncertain exactly what statement he is agreeing with; to put it differently, it is not wholly clear where, in English translation, to place the quotation marks. In 1:15, 3:1, and 2 Tim 2:11 the quotation follows the words “faithful is the statement,” while in Tit 3:8 the quotation precedes. Several portions of v10 provide candidates for the quotation. However, the words **for pursuit of this goal we both labor and suffer reproach** is not likely to be the quotation, since its referent would not be clear if it was a free-standing saying. Meanwhile, **we have placed our hope in the living God** etc. is rather far removed from v9. But the words in v8 **piety is beneficial for everything, having the promise of life [both] now and in the coming [life]** are close to v9; and they are aphoristic, being fairly brief, relatively balanced, and (in the original Greek) exhibiting literary characteristics (viz., alliteration and rhyme). (The interposition of δε is no obstacle, since it is postpositive; cf. γαρ in 2 Tim 2:11.) The words stand well on their own, but also beautifully complement Paul's words in vv7b-8a. So the statement is clever, and it is also clever of Paul to weave them into his own discourse. At any rate, Paul demonstrates in this epistle a keen interest in making use of the intellectual wealth of the Church. Perhaps this is part of his bridge-building disposition (cf. Ac 17:28).

The words **this goal** (v10) refers either to the **piety** for which self-discipline has been enjoined or to **the promise of life [both] now and in the coming [life]** (both v8); it does not make much difference which approach one takes, for, as Paul has said, the two are intimately connected.

There is an important textual problem in v10: Some manuscripts read “we both labor and suffer reproach” (και κοπιωμεν και ονειδιζομεθα), while others read “we labor and strive” (κοπιωμεν και αγωνιζομεθα). The last word in each string is in Greek similar to the eye, and so one reading might simply be a mistake for the other. But the presence or absence of και before κοπιωμεν suggests that deliberate scribal intervention is at work (the manuscript evidence for having an initial και but reading αγωνιζομεθα is vanishingly small). That being the case, it must be asked which of the two readings is more likely to have provoked a scribal response. It is difficult to see why the reading “we labor and strive” would be objectionable, beyond the minor issue of two synonymous verbs side-by-side. The reading “we both labor and suffer reproach,” however, is difficult to make sense of if it escapes one's notice that the reproach is *undeserved*. An early scribe, faced with the conundrum of Paul saying that Christians are deserving of scorn, had the (ingenious but ultimately incorrect) idea that ονειδιζομεθα was a prior scribe's slip-up for αγωνιζομεθα. Having made this emendation, he then proceeded to strike out the then-superfluous initial και. This is all admittedly speculation, but to my mind is a plausible chain of events and explains the wide attestation of a reading over which scribes might stumble. If I am wrong, it can be noticed that Paul gives considerable emphasis to the labor inherent in the pursuit of the Christian's goal. If I am right, Paul indeed affirms the necessity of great effort, but goes further in reminding

Timothy that the world regularly disrespects God's followers.

The basis for Christian perseverance through the toil and the recriminations that he or she will face is **hope in the living God**. As observed in the comments on 3:15, “the living God” can refer to God's power, or his presence—anciently in the Temple, and now in the Church. In fact, this might be precisely the confluence of those two ideas that leads Paul to describe God as “the living God” here: It is his power that sees the Christian through the trials of life, and it is his gracious presence in the Christian community that in large measure disperses his goodness to all the earth—the topic to which Paul now pivots.

The words **God, who is a savior of all people, especially of believers** raises questions similar to those considered in relation to 2:4 above. Paul cannot mean that all men are or will be redeemed: In the first place this interpretation flies in the face of clear statements of Scripture elsewhere; and in the second place this interpretation struggles to make a meaningful distinction between **all people** and **believers**. One view is that the distinction is between those whose guilt inherited from Adam has been dealt with by Christ, and those who have been forgiven all their sins. Paul, however, does not seem to treat inherited sin in this way elsewhere (cf. especially Rom 5:12-21). I think the best way to understand Paul's statement here is to appeal to the potential variability of scope in the word **savior** (σωτηρ). This word can bear a variety of senses, of which two are in my estimation the two most pertinent here. First, in the Hellenistic era (which preceded and in many ways laid the groundwork for the Roman hegemony in the eastern Mediterranean), many dynasts would style themselves an urban or a regional “savior,” by which they meant that by their military might they guaranteed public safety and that by their personal largess they promoted the public good. Second, going back to the Old Testament (e.g., Isa 45:21, where the Old Greek version renders מוֹשִׁיעַ with σωτηρ), the word could speak of deliverance, not only from political oppression and the like, but from sin itself. The first sense, or something like it, obtains with reference to **all people**, inasmuch as God, gracious and mighty, oversees the affairs of humanity, providing rain for crops and happiness of heart in ample measure (Ac 14:17); the second sense obtains with reference to **believers**, who see God's goodness not only in the ways just mentioned, but also in the salvation obtained by his Son (Col 1:13). Believers do not differ from unbelievers in owing gratitude to God for his generosity (cf. Rom 1:21), but in their gratitude to God for giving them a place among his people (cf. Col 1:12). Such is the God in whom all believers place their hope, and in whose strength no toil or reproach can bring ultimate defeat (cf. Pr 24:16, Rom 8:37).

Translation (4:11-16)

Command and teach these things. 12 No one is to think little of your youth; on the contrary, be an example to the believers in word, in conduct, in love, in spirit, in faith, [and] in purity. 13 Until I come, take heed to public reading [of Scripture], to exhortation, [and] to teaching. 14 Do not neglect the spiritual gift that is within you, which was given to you through prophecy with the laying on of hands of a council of elders. 15 Be mindful of these things; be [thoroughly engaged] in them, in order that your progress might be evident to everyone. 16 Pay attention to yourself and to your teaching; remain [attentive] to them, for by doing this you will save both yourself and those who listen to you.

Comments (4:11-16)

In 1 Tim 4:11 Paul reiterates the thought of v6. His repeating himself makes clear that this charge to Timothy is no small matter.

Unlike in the modern United States, being advanced in years was in Paul's day culturally preferable to being young. Honor for elders is a good thing (e.g., Lev 19:32, Pr 23:22) that can be distorted in various ways, such as disrespecting a young man simply because he is young. That is a danger Paul sees in Timothy's case (v12a). Timothy must not be disrespected: He operates under instructions from the apostle Paul (v11), and has a gift from the Holy Spirit to which multiple elders can attest (v14). So his public role (v13) must continue.

It is not a matter of bald authority. On the contrary, Timothy must make himself a living object lesson of what the Christian life looks like (v12b). The phrase **in word** (εν λογω) could also be translated “in the Word” and refer to his exposition of Scripture. But since this is a list of virtues that should obtain in the life of every Christian, and since the item which follows next is **conduct**, or “manner of life” (αναστροφη), the phrase

probably refers to verbal communication (cf. James 3:1ff), inclusive of but broader than scriptural exposition. The meaning of **in spirit** (εν πνεύματι; lacking in some manuscripts) is a bit uncertain. It might mean “zeal”; or it might be a concise way of “in demonstrating an interest in spiritual[, instead of merely earthly,] things”; or, if translated “in Spirit,” it might refer to a marked sensitivity to the values and leading of the Holy Spirit. Reflection will show that these three options nevertheless phase into one another to some extent.

Paul hopes to come and render assistance (cf. 3:14-15). Until then, some items are to be put high on the priority list (4:13). First, there is **public reading**. By this Paul undoubtedly means the public reading *of Scripture*. This would be the most natural way of understanding it in the milieu of Paul’s day, since in the synagogue system the public reading of Scripture was a key—if not *the* key—element. Moreover, Paul’s exceedingly high regard for Scripture (2 Tim 3:15-17, etc.) makes it all but impossible for any books besides Scripture to be what he has in mind. (For valuable tips for the public reading of Scripture, see Arthurs, *passim*.)

Second, there is **exhortation** (παρακλήσις). This term has a variety of senses. Since it is here sandwiched between two terms that clearly refer to the public sphere, Paul is probably referring to a practice (taken over, like the preceding element, from synagogue practice; cf. Ac 13:15) of appealing to the gathered church to take courage and to implement the imperatives of Scripture (cf. Heb 13:22). A slight paraphrase of **exhortation** here, then, might be “preaching.”

Third, there is **teaching**. This term is self-explanatory, except for the question of whether or how far it is distinct from the previous two items mentioned. The Greek wording (τη αναγνωσει, τη παρακλησει, τη διδασκαλια) is unclear on this point: On the one hand, by repeating the article each time it seems to suggest that a distinction among the three items; on the other hand, by omitting a conjunction between the penultimate and ultimate items it seems to suggest that what is given here is more of an overall impression of what is necessary than a precise and comprehensive list (cf. the wording in 1 Tim 1:2, 2:1, 4:13, 5:10). Perhaps it is best to say that the public reading of Scripture, exhortation, and teaching must each be present in the life of the gathered church, though the boundary lines between these items is not always clear. Scripture without teaching on it it cannot be expected to have its full and proper impact (cf. Ac 8:31); teaching without exhortation is useless (cf. Jm 1:22); and exhortation without a proper basis in Scripture neglects God’s gift of Scripture, with potentially fatal consequences (cf. Mat 4:4).

In the background of 1 Tim 4:14 is Timothy’s ordination. The details of that event are not spelled out—a silence that is natural enough, since Timothy is well aware of them, and the details are not crucial to the present argument. The **laying on of hands** is a ceremony in which certain persons place their hands on another as a sign of dedication to a particular office or ministry (e.g., Ex 28:41, Ac 6:6, 13:3), and possibly also in Ac 19:6 to the Christian life itself, though there is some difficulty involved in ascertaining the significance of that passage. “Laying on of hands is not an essential element in ordination, for neither in connection with Jesus himself, nor in connection with the apostles, nor even in connection with the elders (Acts 14:23; 20:28) is any mention made of it” (Bavinck 4:383). In other words, it is not a prescription, though it is a practice that has much to commend it in most cases. It did occur in the context of Timothy’s ordination. Paul was in attendance (2 Tim 1:6), as was an unspecified number of other elders (**a council of elders**, 1 Tim 4:14). (It is possible that the same event is referred to in 6:12. If so, some sort of statement of faith is or can be an element of the ordination process. But while a confession of faith is certainly not out of place in an ordination, 6:12 probably refers to Timothy’s repeated profession of Christ to and before unbelievers, given the way in which Paul uses the same word [“confession,” ομολογια] in 6:13.)

Paul closely associates Timothy’s ordination with a particular gift and a particular prophecy (4:14). What that gift is, Paul again does not say—again no doubt because Timothy knows full well what it is. The same applies for the prophecy. Based on the immediate context, it seems safe to infer that both related to his pastoral office. The exact nature of the close association between Timothy’s ordination and his gift is similarly unclear as to the details, but clear as to the overall intent. Here Paul says that the gift came “through [δια] prophecy” and “with [μετα] the laying on of hands”; in 2 Tim 1:6 Paul says that it came “through” [δια] the laying on of his hands. As it relates to the gift, then, the laying on of hands and the prophecy are singular in intent. That said, this interchangeability does not, it seems to me, in itself warrant Bavinck’s claim that “prophecy and the laying on of hands were not the source of the gifts but the means by which they were introduced into the service of the church

and designated for that ministry” (4:382). Certainly there is no intrinsic power in either the laying on of hands or of prophecy, since God alone reigns over all (cf. Isa 42:8), but the words **which was given to you**, etc. (1 Tim 4:14) seem to imply that the gift came to Timothy only at the time of his ordination. The prophecy and the laying on of hands, however, were probably not even the means by which God gave this gift to Timothy, but merely the accompanying signs of this empowerment to ministry (on the prepositions, cf. Harris, 77). (In light of this, it seems probable that the gift is not the office itself, for then the office would be said to have originated with the other elders, even as elsewhere the call to ministry originates with God [cf. Isa 49:5, Jer 1:5, Am7:14-15, Ac 13:2, Gal 1:15].) Yet even if the prophecy and the laying on of hands were only accompanying signs, they were highly significant for Timothy, for with the touch of the elders and the tone of the Spirit-supplied words came much-needed affirmation.

Timothy's gift is no cause for inaction, but an impetus for action (1 Tim 4:14). Paul himself modeled this reality when, having received a prophecy of a monumental scope for his ministry (Ac 9:15), he refused to become lazy, but instead proceeded to labor strenuously (1 Cor 15:10). Indeed, Timothy must, through immersion in the things of ministry, continue to make progress, and that not just to his own satisfaction, but in the sight of those around him (1 Tim 4:15). Christian maturity is not treading water, but swimming toward a goal (cf. Phil 3:12); and it is not a solo sport, but a team sport (cf. 1 Pet 2:9). The character and the doctrine of the pastor are of utmost importance: Timothy's soul, and the souls of his listeners, depend on the truths of which he speaks (cf. 2 Tim 3:15), or fails to speak (1 Tim 4:16). The stakes could not be higher.

Translation (5:1-2)

An older man do not harshly rebuke, but exhort [him] as [you would exhort] a father; younger men, as brothers; 2 older women, as mothers; [and] younger women, as sisters (in all purity).

Comments (5:1-2)

Since all people sin (Jm 3:2, 1 Jn 1:8), there will come times when exhortation is necessary. While sins against an individual should ideally be handled on an individual basis (Mat 18:15), and all Christians have a significant measure of responsibility toward one another (Gal 6:1), it devolves especially on church leaders, given the nature of their office (cf. the comments on 1 Tim 3:1 above) to see to the spiritual well-being of the members of the local church (5:1-2). Yet this oversight must be exercised respectfully, particularly in the case of those older than the pastor (v1a, v2a); and circumspectly in the case of **younger women**, since their beauty or charm might be a source of sexual temptation (v2b). On that last point, the call to **purity** must not be construed in a way that drowns out the call to minister to young women; pastors must not “confuse the avoidance of evil with an avoidance of women” (Kruger *n.p.*).

Since the style of exhortation spoken of here is individualized (one addresses a brother, for instance, differently than one addresses a father), it is evident that Paul is referring to private conversations, rather than to the public proclamations outlined in 4:13-16. The pastor's ministry is not restricted to addressing the gathered church; it extends also to the scattered church.

Translation (5:3-16)

Honor widows who are truly widows. 4 Now if a woman has children or grandchildren, they must first learn to show respect for their own household, and to pay back their forebearers; for this is acceptable before God. 5 But she who is truly a widow and a woman who has been left alone [is one who] has placed her hope in God, and continues in pleas [to God] and prayers night and day. 6 (She who lives for luxury, however, is dead even while she lives; 7 and you must command these things [to be kept in mind], in order that they may be irreproachable. 8 And if one does not provide for one's own—and above all for one's own household—one has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.) 9 A woman must be enrolled if she is not less than sixty years old, having been a one-man woman, 10 well-known for noble works; [she should be enrolled] if she has reared children, if she has shown hospitality, if she has washed the feet of saints, if she has come to the aid of those in distress, [and] if she followed after every kind of good work.

11 But decline [to enroll] younger women, for when their physical desires become strong in opposition

to [their vow to] Christ, they resolve to marry, **12** resulting in judgment, since they have repudiated their first promise. **13** And at the same time they learn to be lazy, going from house to house; and not only lazy, but also gossipy and meddlesome, engaging in unnecessary talk. **14** Accordingly, I direct younger women to [re]marry, to bear children, to manage the household, so that no strategic opportunity may be given to the detractor[s of Christianity in the world around us] to belittle [the faith]. **15** After all, some have already turned aside to follow Satan.

16 Now if a believing man or woman has a widow [in the family], he or she must render assistance and the church not be burdened, in order that it might assist those who are truly widows.

Comments (5:3-16)

Paul now turns to address an aspect of the mercy ministries of the Church. To judge by the amount of space he devotes to it, he has given it considerable thought and attention.

In 1 Tim 5:3 the verb **honor** (τιμαω) in Greek can mean (rather like the English verb “honor”) to “attribute high status to someone” (Louw and Nida §87.8) or “to provide aid or financial assistance, with the implication that this is a proper means of showing respect (*ibid.* §57.117). It quickly becomes evident that the latter meaning is what Paul has in mind. In the following two verses he conditions honor from the church on a *lack* of honor from her family. Honor in the first sense would not be limited to one party or the other, but it is sensible for honor in the second sense to devolve upon the widow's church only after the family has had a chance to do so, since it is right for a family to take care of their own member (1 Tim 5:4), and since the church must prioritize its limited resources (v16). In other words, where appropriate (see below), the church is to honor widows in its midst not (or not only) with public remarks and with flowers, but with *financial* support.

In saying **widows who are truly widows** (v3), Paul immediately makes a distinction among different situations that can obtain in the cases of women who have lost their husbands. He will elaborate on the nature of this distinction and the reasons for it in the following verses, but at the outset we can observe that—as can be safely inferred from the language of enrollment and the long-term concerns that Paul will raise in the following verses—Paul is outlining procedures for signing women up for life-long financial aid from the church; he does not by these prescriptions mean to forbid temporary financial assistance for any and all widows where the sudden death of a husband leaves a woman in acute financial distress (cf. Tit 3:14).

As mentioned above, the first recourse for the widow ought to be her own family (1 Tim 5:4, 16). (In the latter verse, the two words **man or** are missing in some manuscripts, in which case the Greek behind “he or she” can be translated “she.” Since the difference between these readings is not great, we will bypass discussion here.) If, however, the widow either does not have surviving descendants, or those individuals fail in their duty to repay their familial debt (cf. v8); and if she is a woman well-known for her outstanding character, and is sixty years of age or older (vv5, 9-10), then she ought to have her needs met by the church. The phrase **one-man woman** (ενος ανδρος γυνη) evidently means “faithful to her husband [while he was living]”; the meaning “married only once” would have been phrased differently (μονανδρος). The word meaning of the Greek verb here rendered **rear children** (τεκνοτροφω) is not entirely clear to me: The verb might simply refer to the bearing of children, or it might speak of her having nurtured her children, i.e. to her having not neglected them, but made every reasonable effort to care for their bodies and their souls. Both approaches seem to assume what was most common in Paul's day—marriage for *most* women, and children for *most* wives. The entire list is in any case a broad outline, not an exact and comprehensive list (cf. the comments on 3:2 and 4:13), with the exception of the requirement to be sixty years or older. The widow's having **washed the feet of the saints** (v10) is, I suspect, not meant to be taken literally, but as an expression for humble service (likely based on Jn 13:1ff); and even if it is meant literally, to have done so would have exhibited humble service.

These standards are not meant to be unattainable, or else Paul would not have provided such detailed instructions concerning the care of widows. No woman is perfect, and no woman who is really mature will think that she is perfect. The Church should be gracious in its evaluations. Yet the fact is that there are some women who by their conduct disqualify themselves (1 Tim 5:6-7). In particular, a woman who is addicted to a luxurious lifestyle will be a drain on church resources; worse still, she will by her commitment to earthly things have spent her life proclaiming the greatness of this present earth, to her own destruction and to the embarrassment of the

Church.

There is no set amount of financial aid given. Probably no two situations are identical. The key thing to remember in this regard is that it would be a travesty for any financial aid given to be stingy (cf. v8, Mat 10:8).

Paul's prescription for **younger** widows (1 Tim 5:11a) is different. For them, Paul prescribes remarriage (v14a). His rationale appears in vv11b-13, 14b. From v12 we can infer that it was at that time a common practice for a woman, upon the death of her husband, to dedicate herself to the Lord's service to the exclusion of remarriage. Quite possibly this practice was tied to a general, misplaced asceticism plaguing the early Church (cf. 4:3, Col 2:23, etc.). Yet a promise to God, even if made on dubious principles, is not to be taken lightly (cf. Dt 23:21). In the case of young widows, their sex drive might well undercut their vow to the Lord (1 Tim 5:11b). Additionally, the lack of responsibilities (especially for those in societies that generally lack employment opportunities for women) will tend to encourage laziness and gossip (v13), which, being destructive activities (Pr 18:9, 16:28, etc.), will damage the Church's reputation with outsiders already biased against it (1 Tim 5:14b). All this is not simply speculation on Paul's part: He has already seen this scenario play out (v15). In summary, for a young widow to vow abstinence from remarriage is short-sighted, and such vows ought not be made; these women should not become the burden of the church.

In some modern societies, there is a shortage of males. I think it is fair in these cases to invoke a principle that obedience is required only insofar as it is possible (cf. Rom 12:18a). It is not always feasible for a widow to remarry. Nevertheless, both a strong work ethic and a deep love for family ought to be cultivated, especially by young women (Tt 2:4). Another notable feature of certain modern societies is that full-time employment for women is in many cases readily available. Nevertheless, a fully employed woman presumably does not need financial support from her church, and the dangers mentioned in 1 Tim 5:11b-12 remain: Most often, women who have married are individuals who possess sexual desires that ought to be met in a spouse (cf. 1 Cor 7:2ff), though perhaps exceptions can be made where women (especially young girls) have been forced by others into a marriage. Therefore, at least in most cases, remarriage ought to be sought.

Widowers are not mentioned in this passage, since ordinarily in Paul's day males, unlike most women, would have been financially secure through their employment. Financial aid to widows who truly need it is Paul's main concern here, so it is understandable that he does not speak to the issue of whether young men should remarry. That they would remarry would have been expected by society in Paul's day; and, more importantly, such would be consistent with Paul's wishes here to honor hard work and home life. So it seems that, in most cases at least, young men who lose their wives ought to seek remarriage, though given the lack of an explicit directive it is not certain whether such could be insisted upon.

Financial assistance to **those who are truly widows** is not the only mercy ministry of the church (cf. Ac 11:29, Tit 3:14, Jm 1:27, etc.). Yet Paul is mindful that the local church can easily become overburdened (1 Tim 5:16). Therefore, mercies ministries that go beyond care for qualifying widows must be done carefully, so as not by shortsighted management to deprive qualifying widows the finances they both need and deserve.

Translation (5:17-18)

Those elders who govern well are to be considered worthy of double honor, especially those who labor in [the] Word and teaching. 18 For the Scripture says, "You shall not muzzle the ox while it is threshing," and, "The laborer is worthy of his pay."

Comments (5:17-8)

Paul in 1 Tim 5:17 uses τιμαω (**honor**), and the comments made under v3 apply here as well, particularly in light of v18, which makes clear that financial compensation is in view (cf. also 1 Cor 9:1ff, which addresses basically the same topic, at greater length). If possible, pastors (here, **elders**; concerning the terminology, see the comments on 3:1) are ordinarily to be well compensated. Paul's **double honor** is surely not an exact formula. In the first place, that compensation of which double is ideally to be credited to pastors **who labor in [the] Word and teaching** is not specified. In the second place, pastors are to be **considered** to be deserving of **double honor**; that is, there is a recognition that they are worth much, without a quantifiable remuneration necessarily obtaining in the financial records. In the early Church, most local churches evidently met in the wealthiest

members' homes (e.g. Phm 2), since in those days the houses of well-off individuals typically had an enclosed courtyard well-suited for a small ecclesiastical gathering. Most Christians then (as now) were poor (1 Cor 1:26). As far as I can tell, churches in this era always had multiple elders (Ac 20:17, Tit 1:5, etc.). When the usually small contribution of a limited number of households is divided across multiple pastors, the wage for pastors can be supposed to have been small in most cases. Pastors were, often are (and arguably should be; cf. 1 Tim 3:3) relatively low on the pay scale for a given city or town. So it would be unnecessary and unbecoming for a pastor to be fantastically wealthy. Yet Paul here says that a church ought to aspire to pay their pastors well (and all the more when they work hard at their teaching; more on this matter shortly). Some churches have, owing to thoughtlessness or in the name of frugality, left pastors and their families shivering in windy, uninhabitable abodes; this ought not to be.

After all, as Paul goes on to show in v18, Scripture states that in principle those who work ought to be given fair compensation. Paul cites two passages, viz. Dt 25:4 and Lk 10:7. Paul's quotations (made no doubt from memory) differ in immaterial ways from his sources (word order in the first case; dropping of γὰρ [“for”] and αὐτοῦ [which underscores that it is the *worker's* wages that is meant] in the second case). Such is common practice in the New Testament, which is not picayune about minor points of verbiage (there was not then, as there is now in academic circles, an expectation that quotations be precise). (The use of Lk 10:7 is remarkable in that Paul quotes a New Testament book in a way that makes it as authoritative as Deuteronomy, perhaps the single-most venerated book in Jewish history for many centuries. This quotation, together with other data, demonstrates that the recognition of the New Testament canon was not a slow, controversial process.)

Just as it would be unjust to keep an animal from eating a portion of the food he by his own strength is preparing (Dt 25:4), so it would be improper for the pastor not to receive some measure of remuneration from those he serves. And the teaching of Jesus (Lk 10:7) points in the same direction: He who works ought to be paid. (While Paul's concern here is for the pastor, it should be noted that the same principle applies to any worker, regardless of gender, ethnicity, class, or documentation status.) Or at least, ideally and in most circumstances he should be paid (**considered worthy**); at times, the limited means of a local church or other circumstances might make such impossible or inadvisable (cf., e.g., 1 Cor 9:1ff).

The significance of **especially** (μαλιστα, superlative of μαλα; 1 Tim 5:17) is much debated. The question is basically whether **those who labor in [the] Word and teaching** are *distinct* from the just-mentioned (v17a) **elders who govern well**, or whether they are a *subset* of the same. If the former understanding is correct, then the pastoral office is evidently to be divided into two groups, one dedicated to leading the church and one to teaching the church. If the latter understanding is correct, then of all elders who do their work well, it is particularly those who expend great effort in the realm of understanding and communicating the truths of Scripture who are to be considered worthy of double honor. Either understanding of the present verse is probably possible. Nevertheless, to my mind it seems peculiar to suppose that Paul would here—briefly and in an incidental manner—indicate an important functional difference among elders, without having made mention of the distinction in 3:1ff (or, so far as I can tell, anywhere else). Moreover, one of the qualifications for overseers listed in that passage is “skilled at teaching” (3:2), seemingly an unnecessary requirement if only *some* of those listed are in fact to fill a teaching role. Then, too, in Eph 4:11 Paul closely links the pastor and the pedagogue (there “pastors” and “teachers” are there linked not by δε as with the other items in the list of officeholders, but by και). In short, it seems to me that the second understanding of 5:17 is best. Pastors have a number of roles to fulfill, but proclamation of God's Word is of paramount importance (cf. 2 Tim 4:1ff). Paul acknowledges that study and exposition of the Bible is often difficult (**labor**, 1 Tim 5:17). Peter will agree (2 Pet 3:15-16). But the investment is amply repaid (Ps 111:2, 1 Tim 4:16, 2 Tim 3:15).

Translation 5:19-21

Against an elder do not receive charges, except upon [the agreement of] two or three witnesses. 20 Those who sin, reprove in the presence of everyone, so that the rest might be afraid. 21 I charge you before God, and the Lord Jesus Christ, and the elect angels that you keep these [instructions] without prior judgment, doing nothing by [special] request.

Comments (5:19-21)

Having discussed elders as it relates to financial support (1 Tim 5:17-18), Paul now pivots to discuss how to handle their alleged or real sin (vv19-21). Even in a church as strong as Philippi (Phil 1:27, 4:1), in-fighting can rear its head (Phil 2:14, 4:2-3); and elders, though ideally men of high character (1 Tim 3:2ff), are in all cases only human (cf. Gal 2:11-12), and in some cases will even prove to be wolves in sheep's clothing (Ac 20:29-30).

By **receive** (παράδεχομαι; 1 Tim 5:19) Paul evidently means “accept as valid and actionable.” An accusation from one person of pastoral misconduct is not sufficient grounds for church discipline (cf. Pr 18:17); agreement over the facts of the case should come from two, or ideally more, people whose voices are relevant and trustworthy. The term **witnesses** here (μαρτυς) does not *have* to mean “eyewitness,” for the term sometimes refers more to a decent and respectful process than to a common experience of a particular evil (cf. Mat 18:16, where witnesses observe not the crime but the attempt at reconciliation; and 2 Cor 13:1, where events, inasmuch as they are repeated, are said to bear witness to the true nature of a situation). One person bringing an accusation against an elder might be mistaken or malicious. But when multiple people find that they can among them supply a coherent picture of wrongdoing, such a case merits intervention.

When sin in an elder is evident, there is for Paul no recourse for non-disclosure agreements, forced retirements without reasons being made announced, or anything short of a *public* rebuke (**in the presence of everyone**, 1 Tim 5:20). It can then be expected that the wise among the wider eldership and congregation will find themselves newly careful to examine their own lives for sin (cf. Pr 19:25, Gal 6:1). The dark cloud of sin will then have a silver lining; or rather, God's grace will have been found even in the face of human wickedness.

These instructions are almost word-for-word the same as those in Mat 18:15ff for resolving *any* case of sin. The difference is that a public rebuke is unnecessary in the cases of most church members (the exception being when repeated private interventions fail to bring about repentance), but the public office of the pastorate requires a public notice. So far from undermining confidence in the office, the lack of secrecy and the clear-cut accountability entailed in Paul's procedures ought to boost congregational esteem for the elders. Possibly Paul felt it necessary to reiterate the two-or-three-witnesses principle here on account of a certain tendency which is common in broadly democratic societies (such as the Greek-speaking cities in which Timothy had grown up and in one of which he now ministered), viz. the tendency to treat those in leadership unfairly, irrevocably casting them aside the moment a vicious rumor spreads or a single misstep is discovered.

It should be borne in mind that, as in Mat 18:15ff, what are under consideration are ecclesiastical matters—one thinks of such things as gossip, mismanagement of funds, or the like—not sexual abuse, violence, or the like; in the latter cases, personal safety is more important than face-to-face confrontation (cf. Mat 10:23a, Ac 9:23-25). Similarly, the present tense-form of the Greek participle (translated here as a verb) **who sin** (αμαρτανωντος), as well as common sense, suggests that the sins for which charges can be brought are not sporadic and minor (the common experience of everyone; cf. Jm 3:2), but settled and pernicious *patterns* of sin. What Bavinck says of church discipline in general is applicable to elders as well: “The reason for discipline is not an assortment of weakness into which believers fall, nor the appalling sins that a Christian government punishes (though the church then follows, its discipline being necessary as well), but the sins that cause offense among the members of the congregation and are not, or only very mildly, punished by the government” (4:425).

Given that in general elders are few in number, and that ideally at least they work closely with one another, there is a real danger of bias in handling possible cases of sin among them (1 Tim 5:21). It is crucial to avoid such bias, so much so that Paul adjures Timothy by God the Father, God the Son, and the angels he has chosen (i.e. the good angels, not the servants of Satan). The third element is perhaps a bit surprising, since one might have expected instead a reference to the Holy Spirit. However, Paul often mentions Father and Son together without directly mentioning the Spirit; and, more to the point here, doing so would to some extent have placed the emphasis on God as comforter (cf. Jn 14:16, 2 Cor 13:13), but pointing to the elect angels fittingly places the emphasis on God as judge (cf. Dt 33:2 [where the last line should probably be rendered, “With angels in his service at his right hand”], 2 Thes 1:7). This emphasis on judgment is fitting because the one whose judgment has been biased will face the judgment of the unbiased God (cf. Dt 10:17, Gal 2:6) when he comes (Mat 25:31ff). The Second Coming of Christ ought to put into proper perspective the temptations to base decisions on one's knee-jerk assessment of personalities or on the appeal (παρακλησις, the meaning of which in

this context is a bit unclear; another reading found in the manuscripts is παρακλisis) of a friend (whether the elder under accusation, or a friend of his), rather than on the facts of the case. There are to be no backroom deals, for God sees and evaluates everything (Pr 15:3, 2 Cor 5:10).

Translation (5:22)

Do not quickly lay hands on anyone, nor participate in strangers' sins. Keep yourself pure.

Comments (5:22)

The topic of handling allegations against elders (5:19-21), leads to the related thought that, given the dangers inherent in the wrong man attaining to the office of elder, the path to ordination should not be too swift (v22a). (On the laying on of hands, see the comments on 4:14 above.) Comparison with Tit 1:5ff sheds some light on this passage in that there Paul expects Titus to be able to appoint qualified elders in multiple cities, and it does not seem likely that Paul expects that process to be decades in the making. Moreover, Timothy himself was a young man (cf. 1 Tim 4:12). It thus becomes clear that in 1 Tim 5:22a Paul does not intend to make the path to ordination so arduous that only after an excruciatingly long time could men become elders. That said, great haste in ordaining a man is unwise: Almost anyone can make themselves *appear* to be godly for a short time, and a wicked man occupying a leadership position can result in bad decisions, damage to the reputation of the Church, or even abuse of church members. Not everyone who at a glance appears suited for the pastoral office actually is suited for it; great care must be taken in the ordination process.

Just as a man should not be admitted to an eldership based on a superficial assessment, so joint action with an unknown person or group is to be avoided (v22b). Many people, at first glance, appear to be workers of righteousness, yet later turn out to be the opposite (2 Cor 11:13-15). So pastors should be cautious about giving verbal approval or material assistance too quickly to so-called “ministries” with which they are not sufficiently familiar. By no means does Paul think little of people he has not met personally (cf. Col Rom 1:15, Col 2:1), but Christians are to be wise “as serpents as well as innocent as doves” (Mat 10:16). If a pastor becomes complicit in sinful activities, appeal to ignorance is illegitimate when that ignorance is due to laziness.

Paul summarizes the previous two commands with a third command, **Keep yourself pure** (1 Tim 5:22c). There are many ways in which a pastor's soul can be tarnished—not least by disingenuous people around him—if he is not careful. He who desires to oversee others (cf. 3:1) must also oversee himself.

Translation (5:23)

No longer drink [only] water: make use of a little wine, on account of your stomach and your frequent ailments.

Comments (5:23)

Perhaps Paul senses that his warning about keeping away from the sins of others (1 Tim 5:22), while necessary, might be taken too far by Timothy. The drinking of wine was in ancient times (as in modern) controversial in some quarters of Christianity (cf. Rom 14:21), and so perhaps Timothy's wish not to offend those taking a strict view of the matter has been leading him wholly to abstain from wine; or perhaps Timothy's principled frugality has been leading him to abstain, so as not to allow anyone to imagine that pastors lived a fine life on the backs of low-income congregants. (The latter understanding would dovetail with the view, taken by some, that οἶνος [in its present grammatical context, οἶνω] should here be translated “juice.”) In any case, the manner in which Timothy's concern manifested itself requires some adjustment, Paul implies. Timothy's health is poor, and for him the medicinal qualities of small amounts of wine will be salutary.

Obviously this command is directed to a particular individual on a particular occasion, and so it is not directly applicable to everyone. Yet there is surely a principle here: While Christians should not be afraid of hard work (1 Tim 4:10), or even of martyrdom (2 Tim 4:6), due consideration should be made concerning the needs of one's own health. God will not be disappointed, for he is well aware of our bodily weaknesses (Ps 103:14), and in Christ God took such weaknesses on (Heb 2:14). Christianity is not about self-abasement as such (Col 2:23).

Translation (5:24-25)

The sins of some people are obvious, going before [them] to judgment; the sins of other men follow behind [them]. 25 Similarly, the good works [of some people] are obvious, and those [works] which are otherwise cannot be hidden [forever].

Comments (5:24-25)

Paul rounds out his discussion of character and reputation (1 Tim 5:17ff) with what is something of an epigrammatic statement. The basic idea is this: When it comes to the moral standing of people, things are not always what they seem. Things are not *never* what they seem, for many a person down through his history has been so wretched in his deeds that there can be no doubt where his allegiance lies; and there have been cases when someone's love for God is incontrovertible, being clearly seen through her or his works and words. Yet in other cases, the wicked person has acted stealthily, and only after some time has passed does the evil come to light; similarly, many a righteous person has—owing to the quietness and humility of her or his service, or to the blindness of her or his peers—attracted little attention in this life, yet will in the last day receive public honor from God (cf. Mat 6:1-4, Rev 3:4-5).

Consequently, Christians must be mindful that there is much variety in how and when the inner life of a person reveals itself. Some cases will be obvious, but some will not. Care for and evaluation of people must not be simplistic.

Translation (6:1-2b)

Those who are servants under the yoke must regard their own masters worthy of all honor, in order that the name of God and his teaching will not be bad-mouthed. 2 And those who have believing masters must not think little of them since they are brothers. Rather, they should serve them all the more, since those who partake of the benefit are believers and beloved.

Comments (6:1-2b)

Slavery was widespread in the Roman world. In general, it was not racial in background, and tended not to be as harsh as that once practiced in the United States. Furthermore, there were various ways in which many slaves could secure their freedom. All that said, it is understandable that many enslaved people would feel resentful or bitter. In speaking to this situation, Paul does not call for violent revolution. Existing authority structures should be held in **honor** (1 Tim 6:1). In this way, unbelieving masters will be deprived of a means of attacking Christianity, for it will have been made clear that Christianity does not engender insubordination or revenge.

A subset of Christian slaves in Paul's day found themselves with Christian masters. In these cases, the equal standing of all Christians before God (Gal 3:28) could easily be misconstrued by slaves to justify shoddy work, the slave reasoning that since his or her master is a “brother” in Christ, there is no need to work hard or to speak respectfully (1 Tim 6:2). In response to this scenario, Paul argues that the fact that a believing slave's master is himself a believer ought to prompt the enslaved person to work even harder. Familial love should not lead to affectionate laziness, but to affectionate labor.

Translation (6:2c-5)

Teach and command these things. 3 If anyone teaches otherwise, and does not teach wholesome words, bearing the stamp of our Lord Jesus Christ and the teaching that accords with piety, 4 he has been blinded, understanding nothing [of these matters], instead having an unhealthy desire for controversies and quibbles, from which things come envy, strife, slander, evil suspicions, 5 [and] fights of people whose minds have been ruined, and who have been deprived of the truth, who suppose piety to be a means of profit. Keep away from such people.

Comments (6:2c-5)

By **these things** (1 Tim 6:2c) Paul probably refers not to his instructions to slaves as such, but to the whole thrust of his letter. Indeed, Paul immediately goes on (in vv3-5) to expand on what he has said near the beginning of this epistle (1:3ff). Paul entreats Timothy to teach truth on account of the sad reality that many are inclined to

teach error.

The Greek behind **and does not teach... piety** (v3) is a bit obscure (I have tentatively taken παρεχομαι here to be something of a calque of a late usage of the Hebrew בּוֹיָא), but the general sense is not in doubt: To oppose the principles summed up in this epistle is to be out of step with Christ-honoring teaching. There is a fundamental spiritual blindness in such people (v4). Paul does not specify whether this blindness originates with themselves or with the devil. Either way, it manifests itself in a perverse pleasure in debate for the sake of debate (for the rendering **quibbling**, cf. Montanari 1251a *sub* λογομοχος) and in interpersonal conflict. On top of all of this, there is in such people the idea that Christianity can be monetized (v5). Toxicity of this kind is all too common today. Some pretend that their **unhealthy desire for controversies** is actually a deep commitment to proper doctrine; that their **quibbles** are really scholarly depth (both those with and those without academic credentials can be guilty of these things); that their **evil suspicions** are in fact protection for the flock (one thinks of some who continually post videos online in which they impugn the character of some public figure); and so on, perhaps even blindly (v4) believing what they say.

For the thought behind the final sentence of this passage cf. Mat 7:6, Pr 9:8, Gal 6:1, Jd 23, etc. Some people are infected with an evil that is contagious and which must be avoided.

Translation (6:6-8)

Now piety with contentment is [a source of] great profit. 7 For we brought nothing into the world, and it is clear that neither are we able to bring anything out of it, 8 but, having food and clothes, with these we will be content.

Comments (6:6-8)

Having just condemned the idea that piety can be a source of gain (1 Tim 6:5), Paul (in a manner reminiscent of his discussion of bad and good uses of the Law in 1:5-11) now remarks that, taken another way, piety actually *is* a source of profit (v6).

Exactly *how* this is true is a bit ambiguous, for vv7-8 could be taken in at least two senses. First, these verses could mean that true piety imparts a recognition that, since indeed no one has any material possessions at birth or after death (v7), with the simple possession of food and clothing (cf. Mat 6:25-33) the godly people can be at ease, free from stress (1 Tim 6:8). Second, these verses could be taken to mean that the righteous will enjoy everlasting blessedness in the presence of God (cf. Rev 14:13), and accordingly have no need for the temporary riches of this life (1 Tim 6:7), contented during their sojourn with their basic human needs having been met (v8).

As indicated by the passages cited from outside 1 Timothy, both these statements are true. The question here is which of these two things best describes Paul's train of thought in the present passage. The former interpretation depends less on implications than the latter interpretation—Paul does not expressly mention “eternal life” in these verses—and in that regard might be the stronger of the two. But in the verses that follow, Paul will repeatedly mention matters of eternity (or eternity's doorway, the Second Coming of Christ), so perhaps the second interpretation in fact does represent Paul's thought. There is also a somewhat parallel passage 4:7b-10, where eternal life is also that which shapes Paul's thought on a similar subject. For those reasons, I lean toward the second interpretation.

Translation (6:9-10)

But those who set their minds on becoming rich fall into temptation, and [into] a snare, and [into] numerous foolish and harmful desires, which plunge people into ruin and destruction. 10 For the love of money is a root of all manner of evils—some, desiring it, have been made to wander from the faith, and have pierced themselves with many griefs.

Comments (6:9-10)

Having clarified the sense in which piety is in fact profitable (1 Tim 6:6-8), Paul now returns to the dangers of earthly profit (vv9-10).

The Greek behind **those who set their minds** (οι... βουλομενοι) in v9 indicates more than a mere desire, but the pouring of one's energies into something (cf. Moulton and Milligan, s.v.). Similarly, **the love of money**

(φιλαργυρία) in v10 signifies avarice. Note that v10 does not say that *every* sin is caused by greed; rather, **all manner of evils** (παντων των κακων) means that an appallingly wide array of wretched outcomes awaits those whose aim is wealth. Human history has shown this to be true again and again.

Translation (6:11-16)

But you, man of God, flee from these things, and pursue righteousness, piety, faithfulness, love, endurance, [and] patience. 12 Fight the noble fight of the faith, take hold of the eternal life to which you were called—and you made the noble confession before many witnesses. 13 I command you before God, who gives life to all things, and [before] Christ Jesus, who bore witness in the case of Pontius Pilate to the noble confession, 14 to keep the command without stain, [and] above reproach, until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ, 15-16 which appearing the one who is blessed and only sovereign, the king of kings and lord of lords, who alone possesses immortality, inhabiting unapproachable light, whom no humans have seen or can see—to whom be glory and eternal power, amen!—will show in its own time.

Comments (6:11-16)

Unlike those whose love for the wealth offered by this present world, to their own destruction (1 Tim 6:9-10), Timothy is to seek the qualities which God loves, with a view to eternity (vv11-16). Christianity is not simply negative, consisting in the avoidance of certain evil or wrongheaded things; it is a positive thing, the pursuit of lovely and excellent things.

The phrase **man of God** (v11) occurs a number of times in the Bible. It is applied to Moses (Dt 33:1, etc.), to David (2 Chron 8:14), and to various prophetic figures (Jdg 13:6, 1 Sam 9:6, 1 Ki 12:22, etc.). It seems, then, to point to someone who in a special sense speaks for God (as a law-giver, in the case of Moses; as a leader, in the case of David; as a prophet, in the case of the prophets; and as a preacher, in the case of a pastor). Pastors are not infallible. Nevertheless, in their capacity as a communicator of God's truth to his people, they bear great responsibility.

In view of this great responsibility, it is all the more necessary to exert every effort to cultivate the Christian virtues, of which Paul instances six, viz. **righteousness, piety, faithfulness, love, endurance, [and] patience**. By **righteousness** (δικαιοσύνη), Paul surely means not the legal righteousness before God that comes through faith. Rather, he is thinking of something like the practical outworking in life of equity and goodness (cf., e.g., 2 Tim 3:16). The word **faithfulness** (πιστις) could also be translated “faith,” but given the nature of the other terms in the list, the idea is probably the trustworthiness of which a person who trusts in God is to show himself worthy. It is noteworthy that at least three of the six qualities Paul lists here (viz. **faithfulness, endurance, and patience**) are long-term projects, thus standing all the more opposed to the short-term gain sought by those who love riches.

Human history is replete with athletes relentlessly pushing themselves, often against great odds, on to spectacular achievements; and with soldiers who in their best moments skillfully exhibit breathtaking bravery in combat. These striking images Paul evokes in the first part of 1 Tim 6:12 (**fight the noble fight of the faith**). It is a noble task, and one worthy of every reserve of strength, to which Timothy is called. Here **the faith** (της πιστεως) could also be translated “faith,” in which case the continual necessity of faith in God for victory in this great struggle would be underscored. This interpretation would also fit well with the following clause (viz. **take hold of the eternal life to which you were called**). On the other hand, v12 stresses Christianity as lived out, and v14 (notice there **the command**) points to the need for maintenance of the doctrinal and practical purity of Christianity. As is suggested by the translation given above, I lean toward interpreting της πιστεως as “the characteristic content of Christianity.” It is possible, however, that this is a false dichotomy, for key to the Christian faith is faith in Christ; these two interpretations are at any rate not far apart.

The next clause of v12 (**take hold of the eternal life to which you were called**) manifestly is not a call for Timothy to enter into the Christian faith for the first time. Nevertheless, Paul finds it advisable again and again in his letters to summon believers to a deep appreciation of and commitment to their new, unending life in Christ. One cannot have one eye on eternity and one eye on the world (cf. Lk 9:62).

In the final clause of 1 Tim 6:12 Paul adds **and you made the noble confession before many witnesses**.

As far as I can tell, the wording is almost as unexpected in Greek as it is in English. Perhaps Paul's syntax is influenced at this point by Hebrew. Alternatively or in addition, these words could be something of an afterthought for Paul, and therefore not tightly fitted with the sentence structure utilized to this point. Either way, the point of this clause is likely to reassure Timothy. The previous two clauses are, Paul makes clear, *not* meant to imply that Timothy is presently deficient in these areas. On the contrary, Timothy has a clear history of publicly professing Christ, and so Paul can issue these charges with confidence, fully expecting that Timothy will carry them out. Paul does not spell out what and when this **confession before many witnesses was**. Some interpreters understand Paul to be alluding to Timothy's ordination, where, it is supposed, Timothy expounded his faith in Christ in a way that satisfied the elders present. But though this interpretation is possible, it seems to me a tenuous inference. More promising to my mind is seeing a fairly close connection with the following verse (v13), where Jesus is said to have maintained **the noble confession** concerning himself before Pilate (cf. esp. Mk 15:2), an unbeliever. In other words, Timothy, like Jesus, has shown himself unashamed of the gospel, and has not retracted his stance concerning Christ and Christ's claims in the face of unbelieving opposition.

The term **commandment** (εντολη) in 1 Tim 6:14 is likely a summary for all of the core truths Paul has explained and emphasized in this epistle. For one thing, the term has no obvious, single referent in the immediate context; for another, the present pericope is itself one of summary and emphasis. Paul does not often use this word, but the high stakes involved and the attention Paul will shortly (viz., in v16) give to the kingly authority of God warrant the use of this strong term. The Greek makes clear that **without stain, [and] above reproach** refers not to Timothy, but to the commandment. It is of paramount importance to preserve Christian teaching from dilution with the sin of outsiders or from misrepresentation due to the carelessness of its practitioners. Such preservation must continue until the work of the Church is done, completion being signaled by Christ's return.

I have translated vv15-16 as a unit (there was no division of this or any other New Testament book into verses in the original manuscripts; such is a later convention for the sake of convenience of citation), since otherwise considerable paraphrase is necessary to translate the Greek into English. As it is, the requirements of English word order have led to **will show in its own time** ending the sentence rather than **to whom be glory and eternal power, amen**. The sentence (which begins in v13), then, though certainly predicting the visible return of Christ in Greek, has as its crescendo not a note of prediction, but one of praise.

The return of Christ will be at the proper time (v15; on the grammatically plural καιροις cf. the comments on 2:6 above), neither too soon, nor too late. The perfection of its timing is guaranteed by the fact that it is God the Father whose unstoppable power and blinding holiness will see to its proper execution. The words **only** and **alone** in these verses implicitly contrast the Father not with the other two members of the Trinity, but with any mere mortals who might compete with him, as is made clear both by how Paul elsewhere construes relationships within the Trinity (cf., e.g., 1 Cor 12:11, Phil 2:6 on the sovereignty and divinity shared by the Spirit and the Son with the Father) and by his statement **no humans** (ουδεις ανθρωπων) can behold his glory. That glory in an importance sense actually *has* become visible in Christ (Jn 1:14), as Paul elsewhere gladly acknowledges (Col 1:19); yet the Father, though manifesting his love in his Son, nevertheless continues to exhibit a transcendence which forever leaves the Church in dependence on him and in awe of him. The gospel is not a diminution of God's unfathomable majesty and unending capacity; it is the true path by which such is recognized and respected. To this God the Church can do nothing but offer up a breathless prayer of agreement (**amen!**)

Translation (6:17-19)

Those who are rich in this present age command not to be conceited, neither to be found to have set their hope in the uncertainty of riches, but [to have set their hope] in the living God, who provides to all us all things richly to enjoy; 18 to be doing good; to be rich in in noble deeds; to be generous, [and] sharing; 19 saving up for themselves a good foundation for what is coming, in order that they might take hold of eternal life.

Comments (6:17-19)

Paul returns to the subject of the wealthy (begun in 1 Tim 6:6; vv11-16 digress to point Timothy to conduct befitting an overseer, and to the theological basis for such conduct). Those whose present life is comfortable

(v17) can easily succumb to pride, and in any case wealth is an unsteady support—as, for instance, the modern day cycle of boom and bust repeatedly demonstrates. Their source of security must not be in the power of money but in the power of God (the idea of power is emphasized in describing God as **the living** one—though some notable manuscripts lack this descriptor). It is not that being poor is intrinsically a good thing. Still less is God to be viewed as continually dispensing discomfort. On the contrary, God's world has been fully furnished (Paul plays off the words **rich** and **richly** in this verse and in the next) with many good things, the enjoyment of which is only appropriate (cf. Ps 104:14-15, Ac 14:17). Indeed, Paul gets out ahead of any sense of hopelessness that the wealthy among the congregation in Ephesus might begin to feel in light of the warnings found in this passage: It is not as if a ruinous end is inevitable for them. The rich have many opportunities to use the resources God has given them to much good in the present life (1 Tim 6:18); and to save up, not large sums of money in their bank accounts, but treasures in heaven (v19). (For **eternal life**, some manuscripts have “what is truly life.” The textual discussion is complex and nuanced, but the sense is not much different whichever reading one follows. The reading followed in the translation above does, however, constitute a fitting counterpoint to **this present age** in v17.)

Translation (6:20-21a)

Timothy, guard that which has been entrusted to you, turning aside from profane chatter and the opposition [to true Christian teaching] which is wrongly called “Knowledge.” 21 Certain people, professing themselves to be teachers of this knowledge, have gone astray from the faith.

Comments (6:20-21a)

In addressing Timothy directly by name, in calling for faithfulness to the total message of the Christian faith, and in following up with a warning about false teachers who are going astray, Paul here (1 Tim 6:20-21a) reiterates 1:18-19. Clearly these instructions and this information is important to Paul, since he repeats it so often; and here he underscores the message with a particle of emotion (Ω; this particle is left untranslated above, since a direct translation would in English tend to impart a shade of formality lacking in the original).

The alternative to that Christian message is something which is unholy (**profane**, βεβηλος); useless (**chatter**, κενοφωνία); and stands not alongside of, but against, God's truth (**the opposition**, αντιθεσις). Of course, no one advocating such an alternative to Christian teaching identifies this alternative by those labels. Indeed, in Paul's day apparently some called their preferred school of thought “**Knowledge**” (γνωσις; though perhaps this term should be translated with a lower-case “k,” in which case Paul is not saying that the false teachers used this term specifically). (It is possible, though not certain, that Paul refers here to an ideological movement which evolved into the later school of thought known as “Gnosticism.”) For all the self-importance of these teachers of “Knowledge” (on the translation of επαγγελλομαι, cf. Moulton and Milligan s.v.), the path they have set for themselves has been one which leads *away* from the Christian faith. Timothy must not follow them.

Translation (6:21b)

Grace be with you, amen.

Comments (6:21b)

The manuscripts vary over whether the **you** is singular (σου), referring to Timothy alone; or plural (υμων), referring to Timothy and all those who happen to be with him. There is also variation as to whether to include **amen** (αμην) or not. As to the first question, I tend to prefer the singular, thinking the plural to be a scribal assimilation to 2 Tim 4:22. As to the second question, I prefer retaining the **amen**, in which case a final, pious appeal to God confirms the noble sentiments of the foregoing epistle. The details of these textual matters need not detain us here, for the overall sense and tone is not greatly affected.

Grace (χαρις) refers to a favorable disposition of a superior toward an inferior; and, especially in the New Testament, is typically assumed to refer to *undeserved* favor. Timothy, like Paul, is a man who stands in need of God's unmerited blessing. So does every Christian (Rev 22:21).

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